**Aquifer Open Study Notes**

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# Exodus

## Exodus 1:1

- Israel is the name God had given to Jacob, son of Isaac and grandson of Abraham (Genesis 32:28).
- Years earlier, Jacob and his family moved to Egypt to escape a severe drought (see Genesis 46:1–7). His son Joseph's wisdom and leadership guaranteed a steady grain supply (see Genesis 41:25–49; Genesis 42:1–2; 45:5–7).

## Exodus 1:1–22

The need for rescue was clearly related to the Israelites' condition. The Egyptians forced the people of Israel to work without mercy (1:13). It was also related to promises God had made to the patriarchs years earlier.

The Lord had promised Abraham that his descendants would become a great nation, living freely in the land of Canaan. At this time, Abraham's descendants were slaves in Egypt under a pharaoh who wanted to destroy them as a people. God would have to rescue them to fulfill his promises.

## Exodus 1:2–4

To learn about the births of Jacob's sons, see Genesis 29:31–30:24 and 35:16–18.

## Exodus 1:5

- seventy: The number 75 in the ancient Greek version and the Dead Sea Scrolls might include the five sons of Ephraim and Manasseh (Numbers 26:29, 35).
- His jealous brothers sold Joseph, Jacob's eleventh son, into Egyptian slavery (Genesis 37:18–28). God did good for his people even though Joseph's brothers sinned. When Joseph was in Egypt, God used him to save the chosen people during a severe famine. Without Joseph, the famine could have destroyed them (Genesis 42:1–2; 50:19–20).

## Exodus 1:6–7

Jacob's family stayed in Egypt for a long time as part of God's plan. God told Abraham that his descendants would not receive the land of Canaan for 400 years, until the Canaanites' sins were complete (Genesis 15:13–16).

Even in Egypt, God's promises were working. The descendants of the elderly Abraham and barren Sarah multiplied … exceedingly, just as God had said (Genesis 15:5). This was because God blessed them (Psalm 105:24).

## Exodus 1:8–10

From about 1650 to 1550 BC, Semitic invaders ruled northern Egypt, where the Israelites lived. The Egyptians called these rulers "shepherd kings" or Hyksos. Semitic peoples were ancient groups from the Middle East and North Africa, known for their shared languages (such as Hebrew, Aramaic, or Arabic) and cultural traditions.

Many scholars think these kings supported the Israelites, who might have allied with them. Egypt finally expelled the invaders around 1540 BC. The new rulers of Egypt's 18th Dynasty probably did not trust any remaining Semites, including the Israelites.

## Exodus 1:10

The people Pharaoh called our enemies were probably the remaining Hyksos (see study note on 1:8–10).

## Exodus 1:11

Archaeologists have identified Pithom and Rameses with the modern cities of Tell el-Maskhutah and Qantir. Ancient remains show people built these cities during the Late Bronze period (1550–1250 BC), when the Israelites were also present.

## Exodus 1:12

Even though the Egyptians worked together to oppress them, the Israelites continued to multiply and spread throughout the land. In this way, God was keeping his promise to give Abraham many descendants (Genesis 15:5).

## Exodus 1:14

The Egyptians could only get stone for building from the far south of the country. In the north, where the Hebrews lived, they used stone only for the most important state and religious buildings.

They built other structures with mortar and bricks made from durable clay. They mixed in seashells or straw to bind it together. After sun-drying in a mold, these materials were surprisingly strong. This was especially true in Egypt, where there was little rain or humidity.

## Exodus 1:15

- Pharaoh is a title for the Egyptian ruler, not a personal name.

- The origin of the word Hebrew is not clear. When Egyptians and Philistines used this word for the Israelites, it may have been an insult. It likely described a low social class that other people considered unimportant or inferior.
- Whatever the number of Hebrew people, there were clearly more than two midwives for the whole nation (see study note on 12:37). Shiphrah and Puah probably represent the entire group.

The differences between Pharaoh and the midwives were very clear:
- Pharaoh had great political and military power, but the midwives had none.
- Pharaoh had high status, but they had little.
- Pharaoh was a man from the ruling people, and they were enslaved women.
- Pharaoh was rich, and they were poor.
- Pharaoh could have easily forced them to obey, but they did not give in.

## Exodus 1:16

If the child is a son, kill him; but if it is a daughter, let her live: This command called for killing only the male children. It would not remove the Hebrews as a source of forced labor.

When the girls grew up, they could marry male slaves from other ethnic groups. In this way, the Hebrews would lose their unity as a people. At the same time, Egypt would still keep a large supply of slaves.

## Exodus 1:17

The midwives, however, feared God and did not do as the king of Egypt had instructed: This was because they feared God more than they feared Pharaoh (1:21). Fear of the Lord refers to having reverent awe of him as the almighty Creator and Judge. This is the foundation of true knowledge and wisdom (Proverbs 1:7; 9:10).

The Lord is a friend to those who fear him (Psalm 25:14). The midwives understood that the Lord has more power than any human.

## Exodus 1:19

Some people may feel concerned that the midwives did not speak openly about their main reason for keeping the baby boys alive.

However, this passage shows an important principle. Complete openness in every situation is not presented as more important than faithful loyalty to God and to his people. The midwives chose to protect life and to remain loyal to the Lord.

## Exodus 1:20–21

He gave them families: For most of history, children have had the worthy goal of growing up to raise a family. God graciously granted the universal wish of these women who served him courageously and faithfully.

## Exodus 2:1

- The man and woman were named Amram and Jochebed (6:20).
- Levi was Jacob's third son by his wife Leah (Genesis 29:34).

## Exodus 2:1–25

Chapter 1 explained why Israel needed rescue. Chapter 2 shows how God prepared Moses, the rescuer. God used the threat to Hebrew baby boys to ensure that Moses was ready for his mission (see study note on 2:10).

## Exodus 2:2

a special baby (literally he was good): This is probably a reference to his appearance: He was a "perfect" baby.

## Exodus 2:3

Papyrus reeds grew plentifully along the many streams into which the Nile River divided in the delta region of northern Egypt. They were light and flexible, well-suited for basket weaving. It is possible that the mother of Moses placed the basket in the water exactly where it was most likely to be found by the Egyptian princess.

## Exodus 2:5–6

The Egyptians believed that the Nile River was a goddess. They thought she gave life and healing. In this way, the Nile was similar to how some people in modern India view the Ganges River.

When Pharaoh's daughter went down to bathe in the river, she was doing more than washing herself. She was likely taking part in her morning religious practice.

When she found the baby floating on the river, she may have seen this as a sign from the Nile goddess. In her view, the child was in the care of the goddess. This would have made the discovery very important to her.

It is also natural for someone to feel compassion for a crying baby. These reasons together may explain why she rescued the child. She understood that he

was a Hebrew boy. Hebrews and Egyptians practiced circumcision in different ways, which likely helped her recognize this.

These factors may explain why she rescued the child, even though she could tell he was Hebrew. Hebrews and Egyptians had different circumcision practices.

## Exodus 2:7–9

This event shows God's grace (his undeserved kindness) and sovereignty (his complete rule and control). Pharaoh had ordered that Hebrew baby boys be killed. Yet Pharaoh's daughter paid the mother of Moses to nurse him instead.

The story may suggest that the princess understood who the baby's mother was. She did not ask questions that would have caused trouble. If this is correct, both women may have quietly understood the situation without speaking about it directly.

Moses was saved because God was working behind the events. He was not saved because someone was tricked or deceived.

## Exodus 2:10

- God did more than save the life of Moses for his future calling. He also placed Moses in a position to receive training. Moses grew up in Pharaoh's household. There, he likely received an education in administration, military matters, and leadership.

In Egypt, a pharaoh was expected to father many children. This showed his strength and power. His sons were often given important civil and military roles. An adopted son of a princess would likely have received this kind of training (see Acts 7:22).

- Moses: The princess gave the child an Egyptian name. This name appears in the longer names of many important Egyptians. These include the 18th Dynasty pharaohs Ahmose (1550–1525 BC) and Thutmose (1504–1390 BC).

The name Moses may mean "to give birth" in Egyptian. By using this name, the princess may have suggested that the Nile, which Egyptians honored as a source of life, had given birth to the child.
The Israelites later connected the name Moses with a similar Hebrew word, mashah. This word sounds like the name Moses and means "to lift out." This connection recalls how the baby was lifted out of the water.

## Exodus 2:11–12

Moses grew up with many advantages. He lived in comfort, unlike his own people, the Hebrews, who suffered hard labor and pain.

Even so, Moses chose to identify with them. He decided to stand with his people. He was willing to risk his position and comfort in order to help them.

## Exodus 2:11–15

This section describes the first failed attempt of Moses to rescue Israel. He acted in his own strength instead of waiting for God's direction.

This event shows the courage and quick action of Moses. However, it also shows that he sometimes took responsibility on himself instead of trusting God's plan. Later in his life, this same pattern led to serious consequences (Numbers 20:1–13).

Moses cared deeply about his people's well-being. His desire to help was good. But the time and the way he acted did not match God's plan.

## Exodus 2:13

Moses, who had put himself at risk to prevent an Egyptian from beating a Hebrew, must have been especially angered to see a Hebrew beating up a fellow Hebrew.

## Exodus 2:14

"Who made you ruler and judge over us?": The Hebrew man's arrogant question hints at how others would later treat Moses. They would not appreciate his efforts. For Moses to succeed, he would need to rely only on his belief in God's calling.

## Exodus 2:15

- Moses fled: Moses tried to rescue Israel by himself instead of relying on God. This made him a fugitive in Egypt, delaying God's plans for him. His actions dramatically changed his life (compare Numbers 20:9–13; Deuteronomy 3:23–29).
- Midian was on both sides of the Gulf of Aqaba, in the southern Sinai peninsula and the western edge of the Arabian peninsula. A major trade route from southern Arabia went through this dry and barren area. The people there were probably nomadic shepherds and traders (see Genesis 37:28). It was a good place for a fugitive to hide.

## Exodus 2:16

the priest of Midian: His name was Reuel (2:18), but Scripture later calls him Jethro (18:1). It was common for a person to have both an official and a personal name. But it is unclear which one is in view here.

Perhaps, like Melchizedek, he was part of a local religious group that did not follow a pagan religion (Genesis 14:18). Reuel's actions in bringing an offering and sacrifices to God support this idea (Exodus 18:12).

## Exodus 2:16–25

This passage shows the concern Moses felt for the oppressed. It describes his move to a new land (2:18–22). He married, had a child, and lived there for 40 years (Acts 7:30).

From a human perspective, rescuing the Israelites through Moses seemed impossible. But what God's perspective is what matters. The end of this section tells us that God had not forgotten his people (Exodus 2:23–25). He was only waiting for the right time to act (2:25).

## Exodus 2:17

rose up to help: Moses, now in a foreign land, still could not ignore oppression. He was, by nature, a rescuer.

## Exodus 2:18–20

The father of seven daughters did not want to miss meeting a generous and brave man, who would make an excellent husband. We see here the famous hospitality of the region's residents, which continues today (see also Genesis 18:1–8).

## Exodus 2:24–25

The verbs here describe a God who understands his people's needs (heard ... saw) and who is faithful and reliable (remembered His covenant). He fulfills his responsibilities in a relationship (took notice).

## Exodus 3:1

Sinai is the name commonly used for the mountain where God revealed himself in the covenant (see, for example, 16:1; 19:1–2). Here and in 17:6 and 33:6, the Hebrew text uses the name Horeb. Both names probably refer to the same mountain.

## Exodus 3:1–10

These verses indicate a major change will happen in the life of Moses.

## Exodus 3:1–4.28

This section describes the mission God gave Moses to rescue the Israelites from Egyptian slavery. It is divided into two parts, 3:1–4:17 and 4:18–28.

The first part describes God's call. The second part describes the full consequences of accepting that call. Moses not only experienced a career change, but he also had to completely change his life.

## Exodus 3:2

- the angel of the LORD: This is the Lord's official messenger. But the term can also refer to other visible signs of the Lord (see Genesis 16:9–13; Judges 13:3, 6, 21–22).
- In the Bible, blazing fire often represents God's supreme holiness (see Exodus 19:18; Genesis 15:17; 1 Kgs 18:38–39; Isaiah 33:14).
- was not consumed: This may show that God does not want to destroy the object he sets on fire for his purposes.

## Exodus 3:4

Moses, Moses!: God knows each person by name, and every individual matters to him.

## Exodus 3:5

The soil around the bush was holy, while the soil on the sandals of Moses was common. The common cannot touch the holy without being transformed or destroyed (see "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note). At the start of the exodus, God made it clear that he is completely different from his creation. This is important for a proper relationship between God and humans.

The word holy appears only a few times in the Bible before Exodus 3:5. It then becomes the main way to describe God in the Old Testament. In other Semitic languages, the same root word is rare. Semitic people were ancient groups from the Middle East and North Africa, known for their shared languages (such as Hebrew, Aramaic, or Arabic) and cultural traditions.

Holy does not describe a moral quality in these languages but simply what is "other than" human. Pagan gods were "holy" only in the sense of being "other." They did everything humans do, both good and evil, but on a larger scale.

In the Bible, holiness first means being set apart. God alone is completely distinct from creation and worthy of being called holy in the fullest sense. His holiness includes moral perfection. He is perfectly consistent and moral in his character. Here, at the burning bush,

God revealed his otherness. Later at Sinai, he revealed his moral character in his requirements for those who would be his covenant partners (see Exodus 19:6; 20:1–23:33; see also Leviticus 11:45; 1 Peter 1:13–16).

## Exodus 3:6

This transcendent God (the God who is above and beyond creation) had made a faithful promise to the ancestors of Moses. He had kept this promise for hundreds of years.

Moses stood in awe of the one holy and transcendent God of Abraham. This is the God who set himself apart from all other gods.

Later, Jesus quoted this verse when he spoke with the Sadducees about the resurrection (Matthew 22:32; Mark 12:26; Luke 20:37).

## Exodus 3:7

God felt compassion for the ongoing slavery and suffering of Israel.

## Exodus 3:8

- God would not only rescue them but also bring them … to a good … land, which he had promised to Abraham (Genesis 13:14–18).
- flowing with milk and honey: The land was rich for farming, with fields for cattle and crops with blossoms that allowed bees to make honey.
- Canaanites … Jebusites: The list of peoples who lived in Canaan shows the importance of this land between the Mediterranean Sea and the Arabian Desert. It was a key crossroads for trade and communication between Egypt and the rest of the ancient Near East. It was a highly contested prize. It seemed impossible that Israel would end up as the only owner.

## Exodus 3:10

God would act compassionately to save his suffering people, but it would be through a human agency. Often God is known among us because of the way his people carry out his will.

## Exodus 3:11–12

Moses first protested that he was unworthy of such a great task, but God responded that this was not the issue. Human worthiness is of no significance if God's presence is with that person.

## Exodus 3:11–4.17

Moses, in his response to God, presented four reasons why he was not the one to fulfill God's call. Although each reason supposedly relates to Moses and his ability, God's answers show that they were really questions about God.

## Exodus 3:12

In the Bible, a sign often occurred after a person or a nation had already had to decide whether to act in faith or not (see Isaiah 7:14). A sign cannot create faith where there is none (see Matthew 12:39; 16:4). Rather, it encourages the one who has exercised the faith he or she already has.

## Exodus 3:13–22

The second protest Moses made was about his lack of knowledge. He said that he did not know God's name.

This could mean that God's personal name had not yet been made known to him (see study notes on 6:2–3). It could also mean something else. In the ancient Near East, people often believed that knowing a god's secret name gave them power. Moses may have wondered if he needed such a secret formula (special words believed to control spiritual power).

God's answer is direct, but it sounds almost like a riddle at first. However, most of his answer does not focus on a secret name. Instead, God speaks about his faithfulness in the past and his plans for the future. He shows that he knows what will happen and that he controls history.

There is nothing magical about the name "the LORD" (Hebrew Yahweh). The issue is not secret knowledge or magic power. The issue is who God is.

The name is important because of the character and nature of the one who bears it. God is faithful, powerful, and Lord over all of history.

## Exodus 3:14

I AM WHO I AM: This name speaks of a God who is self-sufficient, self-existent, all encompassing, and without limitations, the one being in the universe who is not dependent on something else for his existence.

## Exodus 3:15

The LORD: The Hebrew name probably comes from the Hebrew verb "to be," meaning "he causes to be," "he who is," or "I am." Later, Jews would not say God's name aloud. So, the Hebrew text uses the vowels

from the word ’adonay (meaning “lord” or “master”) whenever God’s name, YHWH, appears.

A Jewish person reading aloud would say ’adonay, even though the text is written YHWH. We do not know the exact pronunciation of the divine name. The widely-used Yahweh is an educated guess.

The English word Jehovah is a made-up term, combining the vowels of ’adonay with the consonants Y-H-W-H. The Berean Standard Bible usually translates the name as LORD. See 6:2–3; 15:3; 33:19; 34:5–6.

## Exodus 3:16–17

- God ordered Moses to tell the people of Israel that the God speaking to them now was the same God their ancestors knew and worshiped. This God would lead them into a fruitful land captured from others. The message of Moses was not a magical formula. Instead, it was the word of God who, although outside of history, can still enter and direct it.
- flowing with milk and honey: See study note on 3:8.

## Exodus 3:18

- Hebrews: See study note on 1:15.
- a three-day journey ... so that we may sacrifice: If we view the main goal of the exodus as rescuing the Israelites from slavery, this request might seem insincere. But God’s main goal was to create a nation for himself. He led them into the wilderness to teach them how to worship him.

## Exodus 3:19

I know: See “Hardened Hearts” Theme Note.

## Exodus 3:20–21

God’s power would be obvious, and the Egyptians would not only allow the Hebrews to leave, they would pay them to do so.

## Exodus 4:1–9

The third protest of Moses was that he did not have enough power. He felt unable to do what God asked him to do.

God answered by showing his own great power. He performed signs immediately. He turned the staff of Moses into a snake. He also caused a serious skin disease to appear and then disappear at once.

## Exodus 4:3

Across the ancient Near East, the snake was a symbol of both death and healing. The person who demonstrated power in these areas was powerful indeed.

## Exodus 4:6

leprous: The Hebrew word for this phrase has traditionally been translated as leprosy. But the symptoms described in the Bible do not match leprosy (Hansen’s disease). The biblical term probably refers to various highly contagious skin inflammations and lesions.

## Exodus 4:9

As with the previous two signs, the fact that the water from the Nile will turn to blood also demonstrated God’s power over life and death.

## Exodus 4:10–17

The fourth and final protest of Moses was that he could not speak well. He seemed desperate to avoid this difficult task.

God was becoming angry at Moses for refusing to accept the truth. The outcome did not depend on the ability of Moses. Instead, it depended on his willingness to let God’s power work through him.

## Exodus 4:11

God created the organs of speech. These include the mouth, tongue, and lips. He has also decided each person’s abilities in speaking.

God can use the abilities he has given. He is able to work through what he has created and chosen.

## Exodus 4:13

After raising several objections, Moses had no more arguments. So he simply asked the Lord to excuse him from the task.

## Exodus 4:14–17

God did not allow Moses to avoid his responsibility. However, he responded to the concern of Moses by appointing his brother Aaron to speak for him (14:16). Aaron would serve as the mouthpiece of Moses before Pharaoh and the people.

As the story continues, the text records fewer occasions when Aaron speaks on behalf of Moses. Moses increasingly speaks directly.

This suggests that the speaking difficulty of Moses may not have been as severe as he feared. It may also

be that his confidence and ability grew with experience.

### Exodus 4:18

Moses was now 80 years old (see 7:7). Even so, he was still formally under the authority of his father-in-law.

### Exodus 4:20

he took the staff of God: Whatever he may have said to Jethro, Moses was going to Egypt in obedience to God and in the expectation of being used by God (see 4:17).

### Exodus 4:21–23

These verses summarize the upcoming chapters. They start with the request to let the people go to worship God and end with the final plague, the death of the firstborn (5:3; 11:4–6). God was preparing the rescuer for the challenging task ahead (see 11:9).

### Exodus 4:24–26

This incident is mysterious. Zipporah immediately circumcising her son suggests she and Moses had previously discussed it and decided it was unnecessary. Why would having an uncircumcised son make God want to kill the rescuer he had prepared and called?

It would seem strange for Moses to arrive in Egypt claiming to represent the God of the Israelites' ancestors, but would not do what God commanded them (Genesis 17:10). This might cause the people to be less willing to follow God exclusively.

### Exodus 4:25

a bridegroom of blood: The context suggests that this statement was part of a circumcision ceremony.

Circumcision was the cutting of the foreskin of a male child. It may reflect an older custom among some Semitic peoples (ancient groups from the Middle East who spoke related languages).

Among some groups, including certain African communities today, circumcision is performed at puberty rather than in infancy. If that were the case here, the phrase may connect circumcision with marriage or adulthood.

### Exodus 4:27

- Aaron's coming to meet Moses is the first recorded confirmation of God's promises (see 4:14).
- mountain of God: This refers to Mount Sinai.

### Exodus 4:29–7.7

In this section, the Lord promised to rescue the Israelites. He said that he would bring them out of slavery.

At first, the people responded in a positive way. They believed what God said. However, later they faced a crisis of faith. They began to doubt God's promise and struggled to trust him.

### Exodus 4:31

they believed: The initial response to the good news was one of faith and worship. Contrast the response of panic in 14:10–12, when they saw Pharaoh chasing them.

### Exodus 5:1

so that they may hold a feast: See study note on 3:18.

### Exodus 5:1–14

Pharaoh not only rejected the request of Moses to release the Hebrew slaves, he also retaliated by making their work harder. The arrival of the rescuer had actually made the situation worse.

### Exodus 5:2

Pharaoh quickly addressed the main issue. What god could be greater than Pharaoh? What god could make him do something against his will? This is a key question for all people. Is there anyone or anything more important than my own interests?

### Exodus 5:3

He may strike us: God had not said this. Perhaps Moses and Aaron were trying to strengthen their case by saying that they had to obey God or die.

### Exodus 5:4–5

It seems that the people expected the freedom God had promised. Because of this, they stopped their work.

### Exodus 5:6–14

Pharaoh increased the workload to punish their disobedience. He thought they had too much free time (5:8). He could not imagine a god revealing himself outside the royal worship system. He believed they invented their unusual religious ideas instead of working (see also 5:17).

## Exodus 5:7

Straw is a binder to help clay and mud bricks retain their form while drying in the sun.

## Exodus 5:22

The phrase brought trouble upon this people could be translated more strongly as caused evil for this people.

Is God truly good? God did not rescue the people from their difficult situations as he promised. It seems he has made things worse. Is he faithful or not? Is he powerful or not? (compare Psalm 105:25–27).

## Exodus 5:22–23

This moment was a turning point. After the first strong response of hope (4:29–31), the promise of rescue led to doubt and anger. The people faced even harsher oppression than before.

Moses, who was called to rescue them, also began to doubt. The situation tested his faith.

## Exodus 6:1

Now you will see: This means that God was about to act. He was not discouraged by the questions about his faithfulness, his power, or his character.

Instead, God looked ahead to the coming conflict. Different worldviews (ways of understanding life and reality) would confront each other.

Pharaoh believed that he was divine. However, he would become only an instrument in the hand of the one true God.

## Exodus 6:1–13

God renewed his promises. The offer of rescue emphasized the main question. Pharaoh asked: "Who is the LORD?" (5:2). While the Israelites needed rescue from slavery, their greater need was to know the Lord. The main purpose of God's renewed promises was "you will know that I am the LORD your God" (6:7).

## Exodus 6:2–3

- I am the LORD ... God Almighty: Here, the Hebrew El-Shaddai is translated "God Almighty."

God was emphasizing that he was revealing himself in a new way. The patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) knew him especially as God Almighty. Now he was making his name Yahweh (LORD) known more fully to Moses and the Israelites.
The point is not that the name Yahweh was completely unknown before. Rather, God was now showing more clearly what that name means through his powerful acts of rescue.

- by My name the LORD I did not make Myself known to them: The name LORD (Yahweh) appears often in Genesis. There are two possible explanations:

1. The patriarchs did not know the name Yahweh, but God inspired Moses, who wrote Genesis, to use it. This was wherever God's grace and covenant-keeping nature were evident.
2. While the patriarchs might have known the name Yahweh, they might not have seen God's nature as clearly as during the exodus and the Sinai covenant.

In Hebrew, a person's name has more importance than in English. Names showed character and nature, and were not only labels (see, for example, Psalms 8:1, 9; 148:13).
Here, make known implies intimate knowledge and experience. In this case, the patriarchs knew God's name, but they did not know and experience his nature fully as he revealed himself in the exodus.

## Exodus 6:2–8

Once again, God clearly connected his present action with the promises he made to the patriarchs (Abraham and his family). God works in history in ways that show his faithfulness. He makes promises, and he keeps them.

God also planned to reveal more about himself than he had revealed to the patriarchs. This new generation would understand more about who he is and what he intends to do. They would especially learn more about the meaning and demands of the covenant (6:4–5).

Why does God redeem his people (6:6)? Why did he first reveal himself to Abraham? Why did he first reveal himself to Abraham?

God wanted the Israelites to belong to him as his own people. He also wanted to be their God (6:7). This mutual relationship was always his goal.

God's purpose is for humankind to live in a loving and willing covenant relationship with him. In that relationship, people can become what he created them to be.

## Exodus 6:7

Then you will know that I am the LORD: The Hebrew word translated know is always about experience and relationship. This word also describes human sexual relations. To know God as the LORD means more than just knowing facts about him. It means being in a

relationship with him where we continually learn who he is and what he wants us to do.

This is the only true rescue from the human problem of sin described in Genesis 3–11. The idea of knowing the Lord is very important in the book of Exodus. The phrase appears many times, especially in Exodus 5–18 (5:2; 7:5, 17; 8:10, 22; 9:29; 10:2; 11:7; 14:4, 18; 16:6, 12; 18:11).

## Exodus 6:9

The crisis became worse because the people ignored the repeated promises. They had not anticipated that their initial faith would produce greater problems for them.

## Exodus 6:10–13

The crisis reached its lowest point. Even Moses returned to the same struggle he had faced at Mount Sinai. There, when God first called him, Moses had protested and said he was not able to do the task (3:1–4:13).

Now Moses once again felt unsure and overwhelmed. However, God did not change his plan. He renewed his command and sent Moses forward again.

## Exodus 6:14–16

The list of ancestors moves step by step through Jacob's sons. It begins with the first son, then the second, and then the third, Levi. Levi was the ancestor of Moses and Aaron.

After reaching Levi, the list of ancestors does not continue with the other nine sons. Instead, it focuses on Levi's family line. This focus prepares the reader to understand the role of Moses and Aaron in God's plan.

## Exodus 6:14–30

This section referring to family lineage places Moses and Aaron within the families of Israel. It is obviously background information because 6:30 repeats 6:12. Exodus often emphasizes the Lord as the God of the ancestors, both directly (from 3:6 onward) and indirectly (from 1:1 onward). The upcoming events were not actions by a new god dismissing older gods (a common theme in ancient pagan stories).

Unlike pagan gods, who only want personal power and often fight among themselves, the true God has one main goal. God wants his creation to find fulfillment in a proper relationship with him. Although God shows this purpose through creative acts, these actions always align with what he has already revealed about himself.

Moses and Aaron did not suddenly appear out of the unknown, but were an essential part of that same people to whom God first revealed himself and through whom he was about to give an even grander revelation. The family lineage of Jesus has a similar purpose (Matthew 1:1–16; Luke 3:23–38).

## Exodus 6:16–20

This list of Levi's descendants focuses on Aaron and Moses. It shows four generations from Levi to Aaron and Moses (compare Genesis 15:16). The Israelites lived in Egypt for 430 years (see Exodus 12:40–41; Genesis 15:13). So, this list of ancestors does not include many generations.

Genesis 46:11 lists Gershon, Kohath, and Merari. They are Levi's sons who moved to Egypt with their father and Jacob's family. Amram's wife, Jochebed, gave birth to his sons (Exodus 6:20).

The language is clear, so it is likely there are generations not listed between Amram and Aaron and Moses. This suggests the missing generations were between Kohath (Levi's son) and Amram (father of Aaron and Moses).

## Exodus 6:18

The sons of Kohath were Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel. The Hebrew word for "sons" can also mean "descendants." This meaning allows for the possibility that some generations are not listed by name.

## Exodus 6:20–25

The list of ancestors now focuses on the descendants of Kohath. It gives more detail about two family lines:

- Aaron, the son of Amram, and
- Korah, the son of Izhar (6:23–24).

It then names one of Aaron's sons, Eleazar (6:25). The main focus is Aaron's line through Eleazar, who later received the high priesthood.

Aaron and Korah were cousins. This family connection helps explain why Aaron's appointment as high priest caused strong resentment in Korah (see Numbers 16:1–3). Conflict within families is not new.

Korah and his sons may be mentioned in detail here because of Korah's later rebellion. That event made his family line important in Israel's history.

## Exodus 7:1–7

In this final scene before the rescue begins, the Lord again answered the fear that Moses had about not speaking well. God allowed Moses to speak through

Aaron (see 4:16). Even so, Pharaoh would still refuse to listen.

The outcome did not depend on the ability of Moses to speak. It depended on God's power.

Moses and Aaron obeyed God's command. They acted in faith and went forward as he directed.

The first crisis had now passed (see study note on 5:22–23) .

## Exodus 7:3

The Lord would use miraculous signs and wonders to convince Pharaoh, just as he had promised to use signs to convince the Israelites that they should follow Moses (3:12; 4:5, 8, 9).

## Exodus 7:5

My hand: God would show more of his strength during the Israelites' exodus from Egypt. These events revealed that God's power has no equal.

## Exodus 7:7

Although 80 years might seem old to us, it was not especially old in Moses and Aaron's family line. Their ancestors often lived between 130 and 140 years (see 6:16, 18, 20).

## Exodus 7:8–11.10

Through the plagues, God showed that the Egyptians' gods were not true sources of life. People believed these gods gave life and protection, but they could not save anyone.

Instead of bringing life, they were linked with death when compared to the Lord. Only the Lord has the power to give life (see 12:12; 18:11).

## Exodus 7:8–12.30

This section divides the events of rescue into two parts:

- the plagues (7:8–11:10) and
- the Passover (12:1–30).

God demonstrated that he is the Lord of life and death and nothing has any power against him (see Isaiah 43:13). The God of the patriarchs is also the God of the universe.

## Exodus 7:9

serpent: The Hebrew word tannin is different from the word translated "snake" in 4:3. Tannin often refers to a sea monster. The Bible often describes Egypt as a powerless sea monster (Isaiah 30:7; Ezekiel 29:3). The image of a cobra's head was on the pharaoh's headdress.

## Exodus 7:11

they also did the same things (see also 7:22; 8:7): This could be an example of demonic power, but these men could have used tricks too.

When they failed to reproduce the plague of gnats, they said it was "the finger of God" (8:19). This showed their actions were not from divine power. Although the Egyptian magicians are unnamed here, tradition calls them Jannes and Jambres (see 2 Timothy 3:8).

## Exodus 7:14

See Theme Note for "Hardened Hearts."

## Exodus 7:14–25

The first plague was the plague on the Nile, when the whole river turned to blood (7:20). The Egyptians correctly understood that without the Nile there would be no life in Egypt. They worshiped the Nile as the Mother of Egypt, but God showed that life is his to give or withhold.

## Exodus 7:22

The Egyptian priests did not do anything as great as Moses and Aaron had done, but Pharaoh did not want to believe, so it took only the smallest thing to justify his unbelief.

## Exodus 8:1–15

The second plague was the plague of frogs (8:2). The Egyptians gave special honor to amphibians such as frogs. These animals can live both in water and on land. Because of this, Egyptians connected them with life and survival. Egyptians were very concerned about life after death.

Through this plague, God showed that frogs do not control life. They do not have special power over survival.

Some people suggest that this plague happened naturally after the Nile River became unfit for life. However, the size and intensity of the plague were far greater than what would normally happen in nature.

## Exodus 8:7–8

The magicians were able to duplicate the plague in some sense, but Pharaoh did not ask them to rid the land of the frogs. Instead, he begged Moses to ask God

to take them away. He already knew where the real power was.

## Exodus 8:9

In this instance, the evidence of God's power was not in the event per se but in the timing. God could keep the frogs alive or he could end their lives. Pharaoh needed only to say when.

## Exodus 8:10

you may know that there is no one like the LORD our God: Again, the story emphasizes that the Lord alone is God (see 7:17). These events were not primarily about rescue, but about the nature of reality.

Who was rescuing these people? Was it one of the gods, or the one true God, the Lord?

## Exodus 8:13

Moses requested: Moses predicted that the plague would stop the next day. God also predicted that Pharaoh would refuse to listen (see 8:15).

These statements show an important truth. The ability to predict the future is central to God's lordship (his rule and authority). God does not guess about what will happen. He knows what will happen.

God sees the future clearly. He also directs events according to his will. Because he knows and controls the future, he is truly the Lord.

## Exodus 8:16–19

The third plague was the plague of gnats. The word translated gnats is very general. Technical Old Testament dictionaries often translate it as vermin. The English term bugs would come close. The whole land was infested with insects of one sort or another.

## Exodus 8:19

This is the finger of God: See study note on 7:11.

## Exodus 8:20–32

The fourth plague was the plague of flies. The Egyptians worshiped insects such as flies that seemed to be able to turn death into life, as their young seemed to emerge from decaying matter. If the Egyptians thought that insects had the secret of life, God would let them have all the insects they wanted. Some say that this infestation was the natural result of all the dead frogs, but there were no flies in Goshen (8:22), the northeastern delta area where the Hebrews lived. God's miraculous power was clearly seen in his ability to infest one area while sparing another at will.

## Exodus 8:25

Pharaoh tried to make a bargain with God. He wanted to partly obey while keeping control. James describes such people as "a double-minded man" (James 1:8). This kind of person cannot receive anything from the Lord.

## Exodus 8:26–27

- Moses explained why Pharaoh's request could not work. He said it would offend the Egyptians. The Egyptians looked down on the Hebrews and other Semitic peoples. They considered them uncultured and unclean (see Genesis 43:32).
- The Hebrews were leaving Egypt in order to worship the Lord (see, for example, Exodus 5:1; 7:16; 8:1, 20). God's purpose in the exodus was not only freedom from slavery. He wanted to bring his people into a right relationship with him.

## Exodus 8:29–30

I will pray: Moses was learning the role of intercessor that would be so much a part of his life in future years (see, for example, 32:11–13, 30–32; Numbers 14:13–19). It must have been increasingly tempting to let the Egyptians continue to experience the results of their king's stubbornness, but Moses was willing to plead with God not to leave them in a permanent state of grief and distress.

## Exodus 9:1–7

The fifth plague was against the livestock. As with the withholding of flies from the area where the Hebrews lived (8:22–23), the distinction between the livestock of the Israelites and that of the Egyptians (9:4) shows that a natural explanation of this event is insufficient, even if the previous plagues contributed.

The Egyptians, like many in the ancient Near East, worshiped the ram, the goat, and the bull as representing power and fertility. These animals had no power before the Lord, in whom true power resides.

## Exodus 9:3

- Your livestock refers specifically to field animals. Other animals would get boils in the next plague.
- Not every single livestock animal died. Some remained to protect from the hail of the seventh plague (9:6; 9:20).

### Exodus 9:5–6

Prediction again played an important role. God announced what would happen before it took place.

These events were not random. They were directed by God, who rules over all that happens.

### Exodus 9:8–12

The sixth plague caused painful boils on people and animals. The magicians could not copy this sign and could not protect themselves. They were completely defeated.

### Exodus 9:12

Plagues five and six seemed to end on their own because Pharaoh did not plead for them to stop.

### Exodus 9:13–33

The seventh plague was a hailstorm (9:18). It rains in Egypt only a few days each year. Hail and thunderstorms are rare. This storm would have terrified them. This may explain the increased theological reflection associated with it. The plague destroyed the flax and barley crops (9:31).

### Exodus 9:14–17

God explained the purpose of the plagues to Pharaoh. They were meant to show that no one is like God in the entire world (9:14; see also Isaiah 46:9; Jeremiah 10:6–7). God did not destroy Pharaoh and Egypt in one strike, even though he could have. Instead, he spared them (Exodus 9:16).

God gave them a chance to recognize his power. But Pharaoh refused to humble himself and continued to oppress the Lord's people (9:17).

### Exodus 9:16

In Romans 9:17, Paul quotes from the Greek version of this verse when he speaks about God's rule over all things.

### Exodus 9:20–21

Some of Pharaoh's officials began to understand what was happening. They learned from what they had seen and took steps to protect themselves.

But others followed Pharaoh's example. They refused to submit. Pride often controls a person's thinking and overrules clear judgment.

### Exodus 9:26

The hail was not a normal storm. It was unusual in how wide the storm spread and what it damaged.

It did not fall everywhere in the same way. It struck some places but not others (see study note on 9:1–7).

### Exodus 9:27

Pharaoh had to face a clear conclusion. The evidence was strong and could not be ignored.

When he continued in pride, it was not just a mistake. It was sin.

### Exodus 9:29

There is no one like the Lord in all the earth, and all the earth belongs to God (9:14). This was the clear message of the plagues. The Egyptians saw this message, but they struggled to accept it.

### Exodus 10:1–20

The eighth plague was the plague of locusts (10:4). Enough time had passed since the previous plague for the wheat and spelt to sprout (see 9:32).

The Egyptian god Osiris was highly honored by the people in Egypt. Egyptians believed he went down into the underworld and brought plant life back in the spring. For them, he was connected with renewal and life after death.

This second and climactic attack on plant life showed that even Osiris had no power before the Lord. God alone controls life and death.

New plants that grow in the spring do not give eternal life. True life comes from the Lord, not from nature or from any false god.

### Exodus 10:2

God sent the plagues so Israel would know that I am the LORD (similar to Egypt, see 9:14–16). God wanted his people to understand who he is and to trust him.

### Exodus 10:4

These locusts were a type of grasshopper that migrates. They swarmed from desert areas and could destroy large land areas by eating all the plants.

### Exodus 10:7–11

The officials did not have royal honor to protect. So they were willing to learn from what had happened and to let the men go.

Pharaoh resisted again. He wanted to protect his public honor. He said the men could go only if they left their families behind. In this way, he hoped they would be forced to return.

Moses had never said they would come back. They said they were going into the wilderness to worship God. But once slaves are free, they do not willingly return to those who oppressed them. Pharaoh understood this.

## Exodus 10:13

an east wind: The locust swarms came from the Arabian Desert, across the Red Sea to the east.

## Exodus 10:13–15

The locust plague was a miracle. It began when Moses raised his staff.

It also covered the whole land, from one end of the country to the other. The locusts were very many, and there had never been a plague like it before.

## Exodus 10:17

forgive my sin: Pharaoh's understanding grew deeper. He admitted that his pride and his refusal to keep his word were sins. He understood that sin cannot be ignored. It must be forgiven.

However, even though Pharaoh understood this truth, he still refused to obey. His heart (inner attitude) did not change.

## Exodus 10:21–29

The ninth plague was the plague of darkness (10:21). The chief god of Egypt through the centuries, who appeared under several different names, was the sun. At this time, he was known as Amon-Re. He was supreme over all the other gods and was considered to be the ultimate source of life. The Lord showed that the sun's light is completely under his control. God could shut it off from Egypt proper, while leaving it to shine in Goshen in the northeast part of the country (10:23; see study note on 9:1–7).

## Exodus 10:24

your flocks and herds must stay behind: Pharaoh again tried to keep some of his honor and authority after his great failure.

Even after all that had happened, he did not want to give up control completely.

## Exodus 10:25–26

Moses would not compromise. He knew the Israelites would not leave any possessions behind. Instead, the Egyptians would give them gifts so they would leave quickly (3:21–22). Moses also emphasized worshiping God. This repeated focus on leaving Egypt for worship shows the main reason for their exodus was so they could become God's people (see study note on 8:26–27).

## Exodus 10:27–29

Pharaoh seemed to understand that he had reached a point of no return. The plagues had shown him the power of the Lord. The only proper response was to submit.

Instead, he chose another path. If he would not submit, then he would try to silence the messenger. So he decided to threaten Moses rather than obey God.

This pattern appears again later in Scripture. During the life and ministry of Jesus, some religious leaders refused to accept what his works clearly showed. Instead of believing, they chose to kill him (see John 11:45–53).

## Exodus 11:1–9

The final plague was the death of the firstborn sons. The Egyptians worshiped life. They gave so much attention to preparations for life after death because they wanted to ensure that it would be at least as good as their lives in Egypt. Death itself is in God's hand. There is no underworld god who can ultimately defeat the God of life. Both life and death belong to the Lord.

## Exodus 11:3

Pharaoh refused to recognize the truth, but the Lord ensured that the rest of Egypt would recognize it.

## Exodus 11:5

In many parts of the world, people look to their children for survival. In many cultures, the firstborn son carries on the family line. If people have children, they may feel secure. They may believe that, even after they die, they will continue through their children.

When the Egyptian firstborn sons died, God showed that people cannot guarantee their own survival. Life is a gift. That gift is in the hand of the one Lord, the "I Am."

## Exodus 11:7

In the fourth, fifth, seventh, and ninth plagues, the Lord made a clear distinction between his people and the Egyptians (8:23; 9:6, 26; 10:23). These events clearly resulted from the express activity of God and were not random natural disasters.

## Exodus 11:8

Pharaoh had lost control. Moses was no longer making a request. He was now able to set the terms for the Israelites' departure from the country.

## Exodus 12:1–30

The Lord gave Moses instructions for the Passover meal and the Feast of Unleavened Bread (12:14–20). Moses and the people then celebrated the first Passover (12:21–30).

## Exodus 12:2

This month was the month Abib (13:4; 23:15; 34:18; Deuteronomy 16:1; later called by the Babylonian name, Nisan, Nehemiah 2:1; Esther 3:7). This time falls within the months of March and April.

Many cultures held festivals about this time of the year, celebrating the renewal of plant life. Israel's festival celebrated the historic event in which God defeated death and rescued his people from bondage in Egypt.

## Exodus 12:5

unblemished: We must give God our best, just as he gave us his best: "Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Peter 1:19).

## Exodus 12:6

the whole assembly of the congregation: The entire community experiences both the benefits and responsibilities of a relationship with God together.

## Exodus 12:7

blood: God could not simply spare his people from this plague as he had with the others. Death rules in the world because of sin. In light of God's justice, sin cannot be ignored. He must punish or atone for it.

Blood represents life (Leviticus 17:11). So, it is the only acceptable way to forgive sins (Hebrews 9:22). As Deuteronomy 6:9 suggests, doorframes represent the entirety of life as the place of entering and exiting.

## Exodus 12:10

Since this was not a regular meal, none of the meat was to be saved for another day.

## Exodus 12:11

be fully dressed: The Israelites needed to be ready to leave quickly.

## Exodus 12:12

The plagues were primarily the Lord's judgment against all the gods of Egypt (see also Numbers 33:4).

## Exodus 12:14

The Jewish people still celebrate Passover because it was a permanent statute for all generations.

## Exodus 12:15

- unleavened: The Israelites needed unleavened bread (which was made without yeast) when they left Egypt in a hurry (see 12:34, 39). The Feast of Unleavened Bread remembers that event.

Later in the Bible, yeast became a symbol of sin. Yeast spreads through dough, and in the same way sin spreads through people and communities. Jesus warned his disciples, "Beware of the leaven of the Pharisees" (Matthew 16:6). He was speaking about their teaching and hypocrisy.

- cut off from Israel: This phrase means that a person would either be put to death or removed from the community. Being removed meant losing protection, family support, and the right to worship with God's people.

## Exodus 12:22

Hyssop is a small bush with firm, compact branches that a person can use as a brush (see also Psalm 51:7 and study note).

## Exodus 12:25

the land that the LORD will give you: This refers to the land of Canaan. God had earlier promised this land to Abraham (Genesis 12:7; 13:14–17).

## Exodus 12:26–27

In the future, the Passover celebration would be a memorial reminding future generations of Israelites of God's grace in providing them a way of escape from death. For more than 3,000 years the Jewish people have celebrated this important event in their history.

## Exodus 12:28–30

The predicted plague was fulfilled. Just as death spares no one, so no one in Egypt, from Pharaoh to the lowest prisoner, escaped the effects of Pharaoh's pride.

## Exodus 12:31–33

The same Pharaoh who had said that Moses would never again see his face and live (see 10:28) now asked for Moses to come and see him. Just as God had predicted, Pharaoh then ordered the Israelites to leave his land. He implicitly recognized the Lord's power as he asked Moses to bless him. He never formally admitted that the Lord is God and that he, Pharaoh, was not.

## Exodus 12:31–14.31

The Lord delivered on his promises and rescued Israel, bringing them out of Egypt.

## Exodus 12:35

asked the Egyptians: See 3:22; 11:2.

## Exodus 12:37

Scholars often identify Succoth with Tell el-Maskhutah. The mention of 600,000 men in Numbers 1:46 suggests about 2.5 million people in total.

If this large number is literal, it presents some challenges:

1. The camp area would cover 643 square kilometers (400 square miles).
2. A column of people 1,000 wide would stretch nearly a mile and take 20 hours to pass one point.
3. No other known armies in the ancient Near East were this large.

Scholars suggest two possible explanations:

1. The number might be symbolic, showing that God greatly blessed Israel. Although unusual to us, this was acceptable in the ancient world.
2. The Hebrew word for "thousand" (*'elep*) might actually be "troop" (*'allup*). If so, it originally meant "600 troops of fighting men." With each troop having about 100 men, the total population would be much smaller.

Despite the logistical issues, it is possible there were indeed 2.5 million Israelites.

## Exodus 12:38

a mixed multitude: Some of these people later became unhappy and caused the Israelites to complain about their problems (see Numbers 11:4). We are not told why they joined the Israelites. Perhaps some trusted in the Lord because of the plagues. Others probably saw it as a chance for a better life elsewhere.

## Exodus 12:40

According to the Septuagint and the Samaritan Pentateuch, the 430 years span from the promise to Abraham until the exodus from Egypt (Genesis 12; 15). Compare Galatians 3:17; see also Exodus Book Introduction, The Date of the Exodus.

## Exodus 12:43–50

These extra instructions for celebrating Passover mainly refer to outsiders and foreigners (12:43; 12:48). The presence of non-Israelite groups in the community might have led to these rules (12:38). The main point was whether the person was willing to fully join Israel and obey the Lord by being circumcised.

## Exodus 12:46

you may not break any of the bones: The apostle John refers to this rule about Passover lambs when he reports that they did not break the legs of Jesus when he was on the cross (John 19:36).

## Exodus 12:51

The Israelites left Egypt in an orderly way, like a large army. The Lord led them as their commander and leader.

## Exodus 13:1–10

This review of the customs for Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread prepares the way for teaching about the dedication of the firstborn (13:11–16).

## Exodus 13:1–16

Like the Passover celebration, the dedication of the firstborn helped the people remember what God did during the Passover. God spared the firstborn sons of Israel. Because of this, those firstborn sons belonged to him and had to be redeemed (bought back with a price).

Each year, the people sacrificed and ate a lamb. This act pointed forward to what God would do by giving his Son, Jesus Christ, as a substitute. All people deserve death because of sin. But God redeems them through a price, the life of his Son.

## Exodus 13:5

a land flowing with milk and honey: This describes a land that is rich and good for farming. There is grass for cattle to eat, and there are many plants and flowers. From these flowers, bees can make honey.

## Exodus 13:9

- The annual Passover celebration was a sign to show you belonged to the Lord. It marked his ownership, reinforcing a spiritual truth.
- a sign ... and a reminder ... the Law of the LORD: The second part of the verse can be seen either as a statement to recite or as a description of the God's work.

## Exodus 13:13

Parents had to redeem their firstborn son. They could not sacrifice him to the Lord, as child sacrifice is condemned throughout Scripture (see Leviticus 18:21; 20:2; Ezekiel 23:37–39).

## Exodus 13:16

Like the yearly Passover celebration, dedicating the firstborn to the Lord was a visible sign of belonging to the LORD (13:9).

## Exodus 13:17–18

If the people face war: The Israelites had not yet seen God fight on their behalf. Even though they left Egypt like an army ready for battle (13:18; see also 12:51), it was only an appearance. Until they experienced the Lord as fighting for them (14:14) in the crossing of the sea, they were not ready to face enemies in the promised land.

## Exodus 13:17–14.4

The Lord's redemptive power was demonstrated as he brought Israel into a place where they were completely helpless and had to either rely on him for rescue or die.

At the time, it might have seemed foolish. But Israel would thank God throughout its history for guiding them to that situation (see Psalm 106:7–12; compare Isaiah 12:2–6).

## Exodus 13:18

- around by the way: There is disagreement among scholars about the identification of some of the sites mentioned (13:20; 14:2). So, there is little agreement on the exact route the Israelites took.
- Red Sea (literally sea of reeds): The actual Red Sea is too far south. The Sea of Reeds was part of the Red Sea, probably located at the northern end of the Gulf of Suez.

## Exodus 13:19

Joseph knew that God would not leave his people in Egypt forever. God had promised them the land of Canaan (see Genesis 50:24–25).

## Exodus 13:20

The locations of Succoth and Etham are uncertain, although the reference to the edge of the wilderness suggests that they were in the region southeast of the Nile delta toward the Gulf of Suez.

## Exodus 13:21

The pillar of cloud and pillar of fire stayed with the Israelites for the next 40 years.

## Exodus 14:2

- The exact locations of Pi-hahiroth, Migdol, and Baal-zephon are unknown.
- the sea: See study note on 13:18.

## Exodus 14:4

- know that I am the LORD: This event was the climactic (final and most important) demonstration of the Lord's character and power in the Exodus. Through it, God showed clearly who he is and what he can do.

Rescue comes through God's self-revelation. This means that God saves people by making himself known.

God does this by entering into human life and experience. He makes himself present and active among his people.

- this is what the Israelites did: In this part of the book, the Israelites were obedient to God's commands (12:35, 50). Unfortunately, they did not continue this pattern after crossing the Red Sea.

## Exodus 14:5–14

Pharaoh and his officials did not truly repent. Once the immediate fear faded, they focused on their own interests and they determined to recapture their slave labor.

## Exodus 14:6–7

chariot: At this time in history, the Egyptian light chariot was the top weapon. Pulled by three horses, it was fast and easy to maneuver. Sometimes one

person operated it, but some ancient pictures show a driver with a warrior. The mention of officers may suggest these two-man teams. The world's strongest military power was gathering against the Hebrews.

## Exodus 14:9

Today, we do not know the exact place where these events happened (see study note on 14:2). However, the original narrator and the first people to hear this story did know the location.

We should not assume that the account is fictional just because we lack precise geographic details today. The story is presented as a real event that took place in a known setting.

## Exodus 14:10–12

This complaint is the first of many that would follow during the next 40 years. Instead of trusting the God who had shown his great power, the Israelites turned against the one who had rescued them.

Their response shows a deeper problem. An unsurrendered heart (a person's inner attitude, will, or decision-making center) prefers safety over trust.

In simple terms, their attitude was this: "It is better to return to the security of slavery than to face the risk of trusting God."

## Exodus 14:13–14

At least one person learned from the plagues and applied it to this crisis of faith. Moses did not know what God would do, but he made one of the great statements of faith in the Bible. Moses expressed his confidence in God. It was not the Lord who would fail, but the Egyptians.

## Exodus 14:15–31

The escape through the Red Sea was the climactic moment of rescue. It was the highest point of God's saving work in the exodus from Egypt.

## Exodus 14:17

honor: The Hebrew word translated as honor (kabod) suggests weightiness, importance, and reality. It describes something solid and true. It is not just brightness or outward beauty.

In this event, God showed that he is real and powerful. At the same time, he showed that the political, military, and material glory of one of the greatest human cultures was weak and temporary. It was only a thin covering that could not stand before him.

## Exodus 14:19–25

The night before, the Hebrews were afraid and in a panic. Now the Egyptian army was confused and in disorder. Even though they were highly trained, they could not keep control.

They realized that they faced a power greater than themselves. They could not understand it, and they could not control it.

## Exodus 14:22

As with the plagues, natural explanations for this event miss the main point. Some people suggest that a strong wind could push back shallow water. That can happen in nature.

However, a steady wind does not create dry ground with walls of water on both sides. The Bible describes something greater than an ordinary weather event.

The Lord rules over nature. He can act within it and use it as he chooses.

## Exodus 14:25

- He caused their chariot wheels to wobble: The ancient versions differ on the translation of this phrase. Perhaps there was deep sand where the water had been, and this broke the light wheels of the chariots. In any case, the Egyptian charge through the sea failed, and they became terrified.
- the LORD is fighting for them: By this time, everyone in Egypt knew about the special relationship between the Lord and his people.

## Exodus 14:31

- the people feared the LORD and believed in Him: Sadly, their faith did not last long (see 15:24; 16:3).
- To be the Lord's servant is a position of high honor (see Isaiah 42:1–4; Matthew 12:18).

## Exodus 15:1

- Moses and the Israelites: In this joyful moment, there was no division between them. They sang together as one people.
- I will sing: The first two verses use very personal words. They show that God relates to people in a personal way. He is not an impersonal force. He relates to us as one person relates to another.

In the Bible, songs of thanks and praise usually state the reason for praise near the beginning (see Psalm 95:1–3; 96:1–4). Here, the reason is clear: the Lord has triumphed gloriously.

During the dark night, the people trusted God. Now

their trust was shown to be right. God had given them victory.

## Exodus 15:1–5

God's salvation (deliverance) and rescue had meaning for personal faith.

## Exodus 15:1–18

Scholars believe this song of rescue to be one of the oldest preserved examples of the Hebrew language, attesting to its importance in Israel's thought and faith. It is divided into three stanzas:

1. The first stanza celebrates the Lord's rescue of Moses and his people (using many first-person pronouns, 15:1–5).
2. The second stanza celebrates the great difference between the Lord and the Egyptians (verses 6–12).
3. The third stanza considers what these events would mean for the future (verses 13–18).

## Exodus 15:2

This statement is quoted in two other places, Psalm 118:14 and Isaiah 12:2. This shows its importance. The "God of your father"(Exodus 3:6) had become my God. The Israelites now knew God personally, not only as a historical memory.

## Exodus 15:3

The LORD is a warrior: He will strongly defend his people. He is not an oppressor and does not fight for violence's sake. When his people are helpless against enemies, whether from outside or within the people, they can trust that Yahweh, "the One Who Is," is their defender (Isaiah 59:15–19; 63:1–6; Revelation 11:17–18). For more on the name Yahweh, see study note on Exodus 3:15.

## Exodus 15:6

Your right hand: This was usually the arm a warrior used to hold a sword.

## Exodus 15:6–12

The song speaks to the Lord in a personal way. It calls him You. This makes a strong contrast between the Lord and them, the enemies (15:7). The enemies had their own plans and desires, but their plans failed (15:9,10).

## Exodus 15:8

- nostrils: In other contexts, this word may be translated as anger. The hot breath from God's nose is an image of God's anger.
- the blast: The Hebrew word translated as breath (ruakh) is also translated as wind in 14:21 and as Spirit in Genesis 1:2. Nature is not God, but God works everywhere in nature.

## Exodus 15:9–10

Compared to the Creator's plans, all the plans of even the most powerful humans are nothing (see Psalm 2:2–5). They are like dust that can be blown away with one puff of his breath (see Isaiah 40:15–17).

## Exodus 15:11

The gods of the pagan nations are not in the same category as the Lord. They do not deserve to be called holy (see study note on 3:5).

## Exodus 15:13

- Because of God's constant love and power, we can trust that he will keep his promises. Loving devotion is a translation of the Hebrew word khesed, which refers to the undeserved kindness and loyalty from a superior to an inferior. This is the most common way to describe God's character in the Old Testament (see Psalm 136).

If God had this character but lacked the power to fulfill his good intentions for his people, his character would not benefit us. The good news is that he has both a loving character and all power.

- holy dwelling: God has chosen his people and gathered them to live among them (see also Exodus 15:17).

## Exodus 15:13–18

The people God has redeemed have confidence for the future. Because of what the Lord had done in rescuing Israel from his enemies, there was no doubt that he would be able to carry through on his promise to take them safely into the promised land.

## Exodus 15:14–15

Philistia, Edom, Moab, and Canaan are the four peoples that would be most affected by God's judgment when he gave their land to the people of Israel. News of what God did to Egypt was probably well-known in that region (see Rahab's report in Joshua 2:9–11, where it uses the same imagery as in Exodus 15:15, "will melt away").

## Exodus 15:17

on the mountain of Your inheritance: In the ancient world, people believed that their gods lived on mountains.

In this way of speaking, the land of Canaan is pictured as the place where God lives and rules.

## Exodus 15:19–21

In many ancient societies, men and women took part in ceremonies separately. Women often had special roles in songs of praise and in songs of mourning.

## Exodus 15:22–27

- First at Marah and then at Elim, God gave water to the people.
- The exact location of the Desert of Shur is unknown (15:22).

## Exodus 15:22–18.27

On the journey from the sea to Mount Sinai, God continued to care for the people's needs. During the events where he rescued them, he showed his power. Here, he showed that he cares about their basic needs.

## Exodus 15:23

The water likely had a high level of natural minerals, which made it taste bitter. This is common in the Sinai Desert.

## Exodus 15:24

Instead of thinking about recent lessons in faith, the people lost hope and started to complain, as is often the case in difficult times. If complaining becomes a habit, it can lead to failure in the ultimate test, as it did for the Israelites (see Numbers 14; Psalm 95:7–11; Hebrews 3:7–11).

## Exodus 15:25

See 2 Kings 2:19–22 for a similar event.

## Exodus 15:26

The link between obeying God's commands and health is not random. God made the human body and cares about how his people live. In this covenant promise, God told Israel that obedience would bring protection from the diseases that affected Egypt

This statement was made when the people needed water. It may suggest that the Egyptians had been drinking polluted water, which could make people sick.

## Exodus 16:1–36

God demonstrated care for his people by providing manna and quail as food for them.

## Exodus 16:2

grumbled: The people often showed their lack of faith by complaining.

## Exodus 16:3

ate our fill of bread: The Israelites had been oppressed slaves in Egypt. Their complaint did not match the reality of their suffering.

One danger of complaining is that it can blind people to the truth. It can make the past seem better than it really was.

Faith responds differently. Faith is thankful for what God has already done and trusts him for what he will do in the future.

## Exodus 16:4–5

These were the Lord's instructions for gathering the food he gave in the wilderness. He provided enough for each day. On the sixth day, he gave a double portion. This way, the people did not need to gather food on the Sabbath (see 16:21–30).

The Israelites kept the Sabbath even before it was written in the Ten Commandments.

Many people resist a way of life that requires daily trust in God. We prefer to store up supplies so that we feel independent. But God was teaching his people to live by faith. They had to trust him each day to provide what they needed (compare Matthew 6:11).

## Exodus 16:7

The Hebrew word translated glory has a deeper meaning than the English word often suggests.

In Hebrew, the word points to weightiness, substance, and reality. It describes something solid and important, not something light or short-lived.

In English, glory can sound bright or impressive but temporary. The Hebrew idea is stronger. It is closer to royal grandeur. It shows greatness, honor, and true authority.

## Exodus 16:15

The Hebrew term man hu (meaning "What is it?") became the name for the miraculous food called manna (see 16:31). For 40 years, the people ate what is it? Jesus referred to himself as the fulfillment of the

meaning of this miracle. He is the "true bread from heaven" that gives life (John 6:32–35, 48, 51, 63).

## Exodus 16:19–20

For these instructions, see study note on 16:4–5.

## Exodus 16:21–30

The Sabbath was a day set apart for the Lord (16:23). It was also a gift from the Lord to his people (16:29). Rest and worship are not meant to be an obligation, but a privilege. However, because people often try to meet their needs in our own way, God commands rest and worship (16:28).

## Exodus 16:32–36

The container of manna was to be preserved as a reminder of God's providential care for his people. He is powerful and deeply caring. Not only can he supply our needs, he wants to do so.

## Exodus 16:35

until they came to a land: God's care for us is normally demonstrated in ordinary ways, as it would usually be for Israel after they arrived in Canaan (see Joshua 5:10–12). That care is just as real as when it comes in extraordinary ways, as it did while Israel was in the wilderness.

## Exodus 17:1

from place to place: Because the group was large and included people of many ages, their travel was likely slow and difficult.

God may also have used this time to show his care for them. He provided for their needs in miraculous ways. He gave them food and water in the wilderness.

Before he brought them to Mount Sinai and offered them his covenant, he showed that he could be trusted. He cared for them even before he gave them his law.

## Exodus 17:2

test the LORD: This is explained in 17:7. The people doubted that God was with them. They questioned whether he cared for them. They demanded proof that he was present and would help them.

There is a kind of testing that comes from faith. A person may believe, yet still struggle with doubt ("I do believe; help my unbelief," Mark 9:24). This is a humble request for help.

But there is also a test that comes from unbelief ("so that we may see it and believe You? What will You do?" John 6:30). They wanted proof before they would trust him.

A test based on doubt puts God on trial. It treats God as if he must prove himself to us. It places us in the position of judge and God in the position of the one being judged.

## Exodus 17:3

For a similar complaint, see study note on 16:3.

## Exodus 17:6

- Mount Sinai: See study note on 3:1.
- water will come out of it: Note the similar way God provided for the people in Numbers 20:11 (see also Psalms 78:15–16; 105:41; 114:8; Isaiah 48:21).

## Exodus 17:8

Amalek was the grandson of Esau (Genesis 36:11–12). Amalek's descendants were a nomadic people. This means they moved from place to place instead of living in one city.

They were loosely based in the land of Edom. This means Edom was their main area, even though they traveled often. They likely supported themselves by attacking and robbing nearby settled communities.

## Exodus 17:8–16

Israel defeated the Amalekites only because God blessed them and took care of them.

## Exodus 17:9

Joshua was the trusted assistant of Moses (33:11). Joshua would later become his successor (Deuteronomy 31:7–8). This early experience was important training for leading the people during the conquest of the land.

The Hebrew name Joshua, which means "savior," is equivalent to the Greek name Jesus (see also study note on Hebrews 4:8).

## Exodus 17:9–13

This victory was a gift from God. The description in this passage makes that clear.

God's blessing determined the outcome of the battle. Moses showed this by raising his hands. When his hands were lifted up, Israel prevailed.

This pattern appeared again and again when Israel entered the land of Canaan. When God blessed them, they succeeded.

But without God's blessing, Israel could do nothing. They failed when they tried to fight on their own (see Numbers 14:42–45; Joshua 7:10–12).

## Exodus 17:14–16

The Amalekites attacked Israel without cause. They attacked the people through whom God was bringing blessing to the world. Because of this, they brought God's lasting anger on themselves.

God can stretch out his hand to bless people. He can also stretch out his hand to judge and punish. If people refuse his blessing, they experience his judgment instead (see 1 Samuel 15).

## Exodus 17:15

This banner served as a battle flag. In Isaiah 5:26, God raised a banner to call the nations to fight against Israel. In Isaiah 11:10, 12, the Messiah would be the banner calling nations to bring his people home.

## Exodus 17:16

a hand was lifted up toward the throne of the LORD: This may describe Amalek's attack against the Lord and his people. In that sense, Amalek raised a hand in defiance against God.

Another possible meaning connects this phrase to Moses raising his hands in prayer during the battle (17:15). In this view, the lifted hand refers to Moses calling on the Lord for help.

## Exodus 18:1–12

Moses had sent his wife and children back to stay with his father-in-law at some point. During the intense confrontation with Pharaoh, Moses might have feared for their lives. Jethro now came to meet Moses and the Israelites, bringing the family of Moses with him (18:2–6). During the visit, Moses gave him a report. Jethro came to trust in the Lord through the testimony of the Lord's work.

## Exodus 18:7

bowed low and kissed him: They asked about each other's well-being. These were typical greetings in that society.

## Exodus 18:13–16

Moses had begun to take a role similar to Pharaoh's. He was making himself necessary for every decision the people faced.

## Exodus 18:13–27

Jethro's wise advice shows another example of God's care and guidance. This time, God did not act through a miracle. Instead, He used practical wisdom.

Jethro taught Moses a new way to lead. He told Moses to share his authority with other capable leaders. This way of leadership is called delegation. It means giving responsibility to others.

Before this, Moses seems to have followed an Egyptian style of leadership. That system was very strict and top-down. All authority came from the pharaoh, who made decisions by his own command. No Egyptian law code from that time has been found.

Jethro suggested a different structure. By appointing leaders over groups of people, the work of Moses would become easier and more orderly.

## Exodus 18:17–18

This kind of approach focuses too much on one leader. That is not good for the leader or for the people (see also 18:23).

## Exodus 18:19–22

Moses needed to distinguish between his teaching function, in which he received and declared God's decrees and instructions (18:19–20), and his administrative function, in which he applied all of those decrees and instructions (18:21–22).

## Exodus 19:1

on the same day of the month that the Israelites had left the land of Egypt: It was now the fifteenth day of the third month.

## Exodus 19:1–9

God prepared his people to receive the covenant by first reminding them of the past and of what they had learned about him (19:4). He then made promises about the future, which depended on their obedience (19:5–6). The final result was their promise to obey what the Lord has commanded (19:8).

## Exodus 19:2

The arrival at Sinai was a fulfillment of the promise made earlier to Moses at this same place (3:12).

## Exodus 19:3

The house of Jacob ... the sons of Israel: The connection between Jacob and the present generation showed that God's work continued from the past to the present. The same family line was still part of God's plan.

God had kept all his promises up to that time. The promises he would make in the future would also be trustworthy.

## Exodus 19:5–6

- God, who owns all the earth, promised to make Israel his treasured possession. This promise depended on their acceptance and faithful keeping of a covenant with God.
- unto Me you shall be a kingdom of priests and a holy nation: The nation was to act as intercessors between a holy God and a lost world. God would reveal himself through Israel (see 1 Peter 2:9–10).

## Exodus 19:7–8

The first phase of preparation was successful. The people agreed to do everything the Lord has commanded.

## Exodus 19:9

See also Deuteronomy 4:12 and 33.

## Exodus 19:10–15

- In the second stage of preparation, the people received commands that helped them get ready for God's covenant.

First, they had to wash their clothing (19:10, 14). This act showed that God is pure.
Second, they had to set up a boundary around the mountain and not cross it (19:12–13). This command showed that God is holy (completely set apart).
Third, they had to abstain from sexual relations (19:15). This instruction reminded them that God is not a sexual being and that his blessings do not come from sexual activity.
These actions were not sinful in themselves. Under normal conditions, they were good and natural. However, the people had to set them aside for a special purpose.
They needed to focus completely on the Lord, their King, who was about to appear before them.
Only their obedience to the boundary command is clearly reported (19:23). Even so, since no judgment from the Lord is recorded, it is reasonable to conclude that they obeyed the other commands as well.

- Hebrews 12:18–22 compares this event at Mount Sinai with the believer's experience at Mount Zion, which it calls "the heavenly Jerusalem."

## Exodus 19:16–25

The final preparation phase included events that helped people accept the covenant. Some of the experiences were visual: lightning and a cloud (19:16), smoke and fire (19:18). The people also heard thunder, a ram's horn, and the voice of God (19:16, 19). The entire mountain shook violently (19:18). In the Bible, such unusual events are often associated with a theophany, which is a visible appearance of God's holy presence.

## Exodus 19:21–25

The repeated warnings that no one should break through and approach the Lord made the scene even more serious. The people had just seen powerful signs of God's presence.

God is completely holy and far above his creation (transcendent, meaning beyond human limits). People must approach him in the way he commands. They may not come to him in their own way.

## Exodus 20:1

- This corresponds to the introductory statement in the ancient covenant format.
- all these words: When mentioned elsewhere, the words are referred to as the Ten Words (34:28; Deuteronomy 4:13; 10:4). These are not random commandments. They are an explanation of God's basic instructions for human living given by the Creator of human life.

## Exodus 20:1–17

This is a short summary of the terms of the covenant (see also Deuteronomy 5:6–21).

## Exodus 20:1–23.33

The Sinai covenant follows closely the pattern of treaties made in the ancient Near East. In those treaties, a great king made an agreement with smaller nations. The great king was called a suzerain (a powerful ruler). The smaller nations were called vassals (people or nations under his rule).

These treaties usually followed a clear structure:

1. The treaty began with an introduction. This section named the great king who was offering the covenant (20:1).
2. Next came a historical preamble (an introduction that explains past events). This section described

what had already happened between the king and the people (20:2).

In Exodus, God reminds Israel that he brought them out of slavery in Egypt. This shows why he has the right to make a covenant with them.

1. Then the treaty listed the stipulations (the required terms of the agreement). These explained what each side promised to do. In ancient treaties, the king promised protection from enemies and help in times of danger. The people promised loyalty and obedience.

In Exodus, the basic terms of the covenant appear in 20:3–17. These verses include the Ten Commandments. The laws are explained further in chapters 21–23.

1. The treaty also explained where the written copy should be kept and when it should be read publicly (24:7; 25:16). This ensured that future generations would remember the covenant.
2. Ancient treaties called on the gods to witness the agreement. In Exodus, instead of calling on pagan gods, historical events and written records serve as witnesses (24:4). This shows that Israel's covenant was different from pagan treaties.
3. Finally, treaties listed blessings and curses. Blessings would follow obedience. Curses would follow disobedience (23:20–33). This made it clear that the covenant had real consequences.

God used the familiar political treaty form of the ancient world. However, he removed pagan religious elements that were common at that time.

Through this covenant, God invited Israel into a formal relationship with himself as their king.

The Sermon on the Mount in the New Testament parallels this section of Exodus (Matthew 5:1–7:29). The Beatitudes (Matthew 5:3–12) correspond in some ways to the Ten Commandments.

Both passages describe how God's people should live under his rule.

## Exodus 20:2

This sentence is part of the introduction in the ancient covenant format. It provides the historical context that makes the agreement between two groups possible and reasonable.

We are told that the LORD your God offered the covenant. He was not an unknown god who offered this special relationship. He was the God of Israel's ancestors who showed his power and care directly to them. This revelation was a gracious act of rescue, proving he is the only God.

## Exodus 20:3

Not recognizing any other god is the first step toward learning the truth that there are no other gods besides the Lord (see Deuteronomy 4:35; 6:4; Isaiah 43:10–11; 45:21–22).

## Exodus 20:3–11

The first four commandments focus on a person's relationship with God. These commandments teach people how to honor and worship him in the right way.

If the Israelites obeyed these commandments, they would understand who God truly is. This would help them reject false ideas about God.

In Egypt, they had seen people worship many idols (images used as gods). Later, in Canaan, they would see similar idol worship again. The first four commandments helped them stay faithful to the one true God instead of following those false beliefs.

## Exodus 20:3–17

The terms of the covenant (promises between God and his people) describe how the people were expected to behave if they were to be in a covenant with God. The first four instructions relate directly to God (20:2–11). The last six are about relationships between people (20:12–17).

A covenant with God explains how we should treat one another. God is deeply concerned with what is right and wrong. He expects his people to show his character in all their relationships.

Other law codes in the ancient Near East did not include such strong and absolute commands. This may be because polytheism (belief in many gods) does not support one clear and final standard for everyone.

In contrast, covenants made with a human king often included absolute commands. A single king could demand complete obedience from his subjects.

In Israel's covenant, the one King is the Creator of the universe. He alone has the full authority to declare what is right and wrong. Because of who he is, he can give absolute principles, commands, and prohibitions.

## Exodus 20:4

Refusing to make an image of God is the first step in recognizing that he is transcendent. This means God is the Creator of the universe and is completely distinct from it. God is not part of creation.

If people represent God as something in creation, they will eventually worship that created thing. Instead of

worshiping the Creator, they begin to worship what God made.

This exchange leads to moral corruption and spiritual harm (Romans 1:18–25).

## Exodus 20:5–6

- jealous God: When Scripture calls God a jealous God, it means he strongly opposes his people turning to false gods. He does not want them to give their loyalty to other gods (see Joshua 24:19–20). God's jealousy is not selfish. It shows his deep love and his desire for his people to remain faithful to him.
- to the third and fourth generations ... a thousand generations: We must understand both parts of this statement together. God does not punish children for the sins of their parents. Instead, God teaches that sin has effects that can harm future generations.

Even so, God limits the natural effects of sin to three or four generations. In contrast, he extends the effects of obedience to a thousand generations. This shows that God's mercy is much greater than his judgment (see also 34:6–7; Deuteronomy 7:9).

- hate: The Hebrew words translated "love" (Exodus 20:6) and "hate" are broader than English words. They describe not only feelings but also choices.

In the Bible, to love means "to choose someone or something and to act faithfully toward that choice." To hate means "to reject someone or something and to act in ways that show that rejection."
Emotions and choices are connected. What we feel influences our choices, and our choices reveal what we truly feel.

## Exodus 20:7

In Hebrew thought, a person's name is often closely connected to that person's nature and character (see study note on 3:13–22). To misuse God's name means to make God seem unimportant or worthless. One way to do this is by swearing an oath using God's name without intending to keep it. But there are other, more serious ways to dishonor God's name (see Numbers 20:12; Amos 2:7; compare Matthew 6:9).

## Exodus 20:8–11

The Sabbath day is holy when dedicated to the Lord (20:10). What belongs only to God shares his character. This does not mean the other six days are unholy. They are for regular work (20:9). On this special day, we remember that our work does not meet our needs. God provides for us through his grace (20:6).

## Exodus 20:11

To be in covenant with God is to do what God does. Since God rested from his work, we must also rest (Genesis 2:1–3).

## Exodus 20:12

honor your father and mother: This means acknowledging that you rely on others. This is an important step toward humility. Arrogance might make you famous, but humility and gratitude lead to a long, fulfilling life.

Both Jesus and the apostle Paul refer to this command (see Matthew 15:4; Mark 7:10; Ephesians 6:1–3).

## Exodus 20:12–17

The last six instructions focus on relationships between people. Many parts of God's covenant teach how people should treat one another.

In Israel, right behavior toward others was closely connected to worship. Obeying God meant treating other people in ways that reflect his character.

This connection between ethics (moral behavior) and religious duty was unusual in the ancient world. Several law codes existed in the ancient Near East, and some were written before Moses. However, those laws came from human kings and were not closely connected to worship.

In contrast, the false gods of other nations were described as immoral and untrustworthy. The God of Israel is different. His people honor him by treating others as he treats them. See also Matthew 19:17–19.

## Exodus 20:13

murder: This does not refer to every act of killing. The Hebrew language has another word that can mean killing in a more general sense.

The command does not forbid all taking of human life in every situation. Instead, it forbids the intentional killing of another person for personal reasons.

This command shows that God values each person's physical life. Jesus later expanded this teaching in Matthew 5:21–26.

## Exodus 20:14

adultery: This includes all sexual sins. Adultery clearly shows what it means to break trust or be unfaithful.

When a person commits adultery, that person seeks sexual pleasure outside of marriage and breaks trust with a spouse.

This command teaches faithfulness in marriage and purity in sexual behavior. Jesus later expanded this teaching in Matthew 5:27–30.

## Exodus 20:15

Stealing shows an attitude that says, "I have the right to take what I want." It ignores whether something belongs to someone else or whether it was earned honestly.

This command teaches the opposite attitude. It teaches respect for other people and for what belongs to them.

From God's point of view, this command shows that he values each person. God cares not only about our lives but also about the things that belong to us.

## Exodus 20:16

Choosing not to tell a lie can sometimes be a private act. A person might even feel proud about being honest.

However, this command is more specific. It forbids giving false testimony against your neighbor. This refers especially to lying in court or in a public setting where someone's reputation or life may be at risk.

Refusing to testify falsely is an unselfish act. It shows that you care more about your neighbor's reputation and well-being than about protecting yourself or gaining an advantage.

## Exodus 20:17

covet: This final principle connects back to the first, as "greed, which is idolatry" (Colossians 3:5). Coveting is like worshiping the world, believing that possessions, especially those owned by others, will bring lasting happiness. Believing this betrays one's promise of complete loyalty to God, who alone meets our needs. See also Romans 7:7.

## Exodus 20:18–21

The people were very conscious of their sinfulness before a holy God and begged Moses to stand between them and God. Moses pointed out that God's goal was neither to overawe them nor to destroy them. Rather, he wanted their awe of him to keep them from sinning (Exodus 20:20). Jesus is the ultimate mediator between God and people (1 Timothy 2:5).

## Exodus 20:18–26

This section discusses how the people were to meet with God. The first part explains why people need a mediator with God (20:18–21). In 20:22–26, it describes the right way to build an altar. This is before God shares his plans for a permanent sanctuary (see 25:1–30:28).

## Exodus 20:22–26

- The Lord is beyond human understanding, as shown by his speaking to the people with a voice from heaven (20:22).

This had two effects on their practices:

- They could not use silver or gold to make human-shaped gods (20:23).
- They could not carve stones for an altar (20:25). This might be to prevent them from carving stone gods. They must make the altar from earth and uncut stones (20:24, 25).
- The rule against revealing nakedness might have been to distinguish Israelite religious practices from the nature worship around them (20:26). Sexual activity was a key part of many Canaanite ceremonies.

## Exodus 21:1–11

Slavery was common in the ancient world. Sometimes, it was the only option for people who were very poor. Many slaves believed the gods had abandoned them. Because the Lord cares for those in this difficult situation, his followers must also care.

In time, the message that Jesus Christ died for all people everywhere changed how believers viewed slavery. If Christ died for everyone, then all people have equal value before God.

This truth made slavery impossible to defend in the long term (Galatians 3:28).

## Exodus 21:1–23.19

The statements in this section follow the usual case-law pattern used in ancient Near Eastern law codes (legal collections from the lands around Israel). This pattern begins with a possible situation introduced by the word "if." The next part explains what should happen and begins with the word "then."

In these chapters, some laws are grouped together. However, the text does not clearly separate personal, civil, and ceremonial laws. These types of laws appear side by side.

This shows that, for God, life is not divided into separate parts. All of life is lived in relationship with him. Every action shows whether a person is living in loving obedience to God or in resistance against him.

## Exodus 21:1–23.33

The terms of the covenant are now expanded. The first section in 21:1–23:19 gives specific examples of the general principles stated in 20:3–17. The commitments to which God bound himself if the Israelites kept their side of the covenant are stated in 23:20–33. This passage also includes the blessings for obedience.

## Exodus 21:2

A man might sell himself into slavery in order to get money to pay his debts. This law states that the man was never to become the permanent property of the master.

## Exodus 21:3

If a man and a wife went into slavery together, they were also to go free together.

## Exodus 21:4–6

The master was not required to provide a slave with a wife who would then be freed with him. The slave in such a situation had to either abandon the family he began while he was a slave or become a permanent slave.

## Exodus 21:7–9

A female slave was treated differently from a male slave. She may have been sold with the expectation that she would become a concubine (a secondary wife). Releasing her after seven years would not necessarily protect her.

If she were sent away, she might have to return to her father. Her father had already sold her, which suggests he did not want her. Marriage would also be unlikely for a former concubine. She might even be forced into prostitution. For this reason, it was often considered better for her to remain in her master's household.

Sometimes a man bought a girl to become his son's wife (21:9). In that case, the payment was not the price of a slave. It was similar to a bride-price (a gift given to a bride's family at marriage). In the ancient Near East, a young man usually gave money or valuable gifts to the bride's father (see 22:16; Genesis 24:53). A woman for whom a bride-price had been paid was not considered a slave.

## Exodus 21:12–17

The crimes of murder, kidnapping, and cursing or striking one's parents were punished by death. A person who committed murder gave up his own right to live. Human life is very precious in God's sight.

Even when a death was accidental, it could not simply be ignored. However, the law made a difference between murder and accidental killing.

God provided places of refuge (see Numbers 35:6–28). These were special towns where a person who killed someone by accident could flee. There, the family of the dead person could not take revenge (see also study notes on Numbers 35:6–34).

## Exodus 21:14

take him away from My altar: See 1 Kings 2:28–33.

## Exodus 21:17

Anyone who curses: See study note on Leviticus 20:9; see also Exodus 20:12; Deuteronomy 5:16; 21:18–21; Ephesians 6:1–4.

## Exodus 21:18–27

These laws governed compensation for injuries that did not lead to death.

## Exodus 21:22–25

her child is born prematurely: It appears that if a child's birth was caused prematurely and the child died (that is, there was further injury), the penalty for murder was to be enacted. The law of retaliation (the lex talionis) called for a penalty that matched the injury inflicted on a victim. But this law also served to limit the punishment so it was not more severe than the original injury. Compare Matthew 5:38–39.

## Exodus 21:28–32

If an animal caused a person's death and the owner was judged to be negligent, the relatives of the deceased could demand the death penalty for both the animal and its owner. However, that penalty was not mandatory, and the relatives could elect to accept compensation (21:30).

## Exodus 21:33–22.15

In cases involving loss of property, the responsible person had to pay compensation equal to the value of what was lost. If the person had actually stolen the property, the compensation was multiplied (22:1, 4, 7). Where there was a question of responsibility, the parties were to appear before God for adjudication (22:8). The means by which the judgment was reached is not reported.

## Exodus 22:16–31

These laws deal with different situations about social responsibility. They are not arranged in clear groups or categories.

These laws show that every part of life relates to obedience to God. Obedience to God is not limited to worship. It includes daily actions and relationships (see study note on 21:1–23:19).

## Exodus 22:18

The practices of a sorceress (a woman who uses magic or calls on spirits) reflected the pagan worldview (a way of understanding life that does not follow the true God). God was rescuing his people from this way of thinking and living.

This worldview was completely different from the biblical one. The Lord had already commanded his people not to worship other gods (see 20:3; 23:13).

## Exodus 22:20

he must be set apart for destruction: See the "Complete Dedication" Theme Note.

## Exodus 22:21

The Hebrews were to treat foreigners kindly because they, too, had once been foreigners (see also 23:9; Deuteronomy 10:18–19). For more on this principle, see Luke 6:31.

## Exodus 22:22–23

The widow, the orphan, and the foreigner were in a helpless and economically disadvantaged position. God, by his protective stance toward these persons, demonstrated that he does not value people on the basis of their power or wealth, the standards accepted by most humans. Instead, God values people because they share his (Genesis 1:27).

## Exodus 22:25–27

Although interest could not be charged on a loan to another Israelite, collateral (or security) could be required. However, even the security had to be handled in a humane way. The requirements of the covenant reflected the character of God.

## Exodus 22:30

God is considerate even of animals (see Jonah 4:11).

## Exodus 22:31

In the Bible, blood has symbolic meaning because it represents life. For this reason, God forbade people to eat meat that still had blood in it (see Leviticus 17:10–16).

## Exodus 23:1–3

It is important to speak the truth, even when facing evil people, a crowd, or misguided motives (23:1, 2, 3, 7–8).

## Exodus 23:1–9

This call for justice includes a mixed list of covenant requirements. Most of these requirements deal with fairness and honesty in daily life. They show how God's people should treat others with integrity.

## Exodus 23:7

God's character inspires people to act righteously (see 22:22–24, 27).

## Exodus 23:10–12

Renewal, rest, and refreshment are important (23:12). Just as humans and animals are to enjoy these in the weekly Sabbath, so the land is to be given rest every seven years (23:10–11; see study note on 20:8–11).

## Exodus 23:14–17

God commanded that every man in Israel must appear before him three times each year (23:17). They must appear at the tabernacle (also called the Tent of Meeting). While Israel camped around the Tent of Meeting in the wilderness, this command was not difficult to obey. The people lived close to the tabernacle.

Later, after Israel settled in the promised land, many people lived far from the Tent of Meeting and later from the temple in Jerusalem. Travel became longer and more demanding.

This command was likely meant to prevent the people from building local worship centers. If each region created its own place of worship, the nation could become divided.

Local shrines could also allow pagan influences (beliefs and practices from other religions) to enter the worship of Yahweh. By gathering at one central place, the people would remain united in their worship of the one true God.

Sadly, the people did not always carry out these commands carefully (see, for example, 2 Kings 23:21–23).

## Exodus 23:15

At the appointed time in the month of Abib: See 13:4–5; Leviticus 23:5–8; Deuteronomy 16:1–8.

## Exodus 23:16

- They celebrated the Feast of Harvest seven weeks after Passover. This was about the end of the barley harvest and the start of the wheat harvest (mid-May to mid-June). In later Judaism, this feast marked the giving of the covenant at Mount Sinai. This happened 50 days after the first Passover in Egypt (see Leviticus 23:15–21; Deuteronomy 16:9–12).
- They celebrated the Feast of the Ingathering on the fifteenth day of the seventh month of the Hebrew calendar (mid-September to mid-October). This was after the grape harvest ended. This feast remembered the time in the wilderness when God provided for his people.

## Exodus 23:18

- Blood symbolized life (Leviticus 17:11–14; Deuteronomy 12:23). So, it must not mix with anything leaven, which was usually not included in offerings (see study note on Leviticus 2:11).
- They had to immediately burn the fat. This was considered the best part of the offering (see Leviticus 3:3–5).

## Exodus 23:19

The meaning of the command not to cook a young goat in its mother's milk is not clear.

The Bible does not explain the reason for this law. Because it appears among other worship laws, some scholars think it may have been a pagan religious practice. Pagan means related to the worship of other gods.

If that is true, the command would warn Israel not to copy the worship practices of other nations.

## Exodus 23:20–23

an angel: Probably "the angel of the LORD," often representing God himself (see 3:2).

## Exodus 23:20–33

If the people obeyed the covenant rules, God promised to protect them from enemies and illness and give them land to own (23:22–23, 25–26, 27–31). These promises depended on complete loyalty to God (Yahweh). Worshiping the gods of the peoples expelled from the land would be an act of rebellion (23:21; 24, 32–33).

## Exodus 23:24

In Canaanite worship, people built holy pillars to represent the gods. Sometimes, they carved them to look like humans.

## Exodus 23:26

Pagan rites were carried out in an attempt to manipulate the forces of fertility and reproduction. God promised to give these gifts freely if the people would faithfully carry out the terms of their covenant with him.

## Exodus 23:29–31

I will: God, not Israel, would take the land. The land would be a gift from their Covenant Lord. Israel was being granted possession of it as long as they faithfully fulfilled the covenant.

## Exodus 23:31

- from the desert to the Euphrates: See Genesis 15:18; Numbers 34:2–12; Deuteronomy 11:24; 2 Chronicles 9:26.
- I will deliver the inhabitants: God promised the land to Abraham (Genesis 15:16). At that time, "the iniquity of the Amorites" was not yet complete. Now they were. God was not randomly taking land from the Amorites (that is, the Canaanites). He used the Israelites to judge their wickedness.

## Exodus 23:33

they cause you to sin against Me: God commanded Israel to destroy the Canaanites. There could be no peace agreement between a holy God and sin.

God had chosen Israel to carry his message (revelation, meaning what God makes known about himself) to the world. This message would one day lead to the coming of Jesus Christ in human form (the incarnation).

For this plan to continue, Israel had to remain faithful to God. If they returned to pagan worship (the worship of false gods), this plan would be broken.

## Exodus 24:1–2

Some commentators suggest that Moses, Aaron, Nadab, Abihu, and the elders made two trips up the mountain, here and in 24:9–11. However, this command was probably given in advance and obeyed at the proper time in 24:9.

## Exodus 24:1–18

Israel agreed to the terms of the covenant (24:3). The covenant was then confirmed through several ceremonies:

- First, the covenant was written down and read aloud to the people (24:4, 7).
- Then blood was sprinkled as part of the ceremony (24:6).
- The leaders also shared a covenant meal in God's presence (24:11).
- Finally, the glory of the Lord appeared on the mountain (24:15–18).

## Exodus 24:3

came: At this important moment, the people had to make a choice. Would they accept this relationship with God? Would they promise full loyalty to him and agree to live in ways that reflect his character?

They answered together, with one voice, that they would obey the covenant.

## Exodus 24:4

Pillars were set up as memorial stones. They showed that something important had happened at that place and time.

In Hittite treaties, people called on their pagan gods to witness the agreement. The gods were believed to see and confirm the treaty.

However, the Hebrews were not allowed to recognize other gods. Instead of calling on false gods as witnesses, they used stone pillars to mark the agreement.

## Exodus 24:6

When Moses sprinkled half of the sacrificial animals' blood on the altar, he symbolized God's formal oath to keep his covenant (see Genesis 15:9–18; Hebrews 6:13).

## Exodus 24:7

People were required to write down treaties and read them aloud in public. It is very likely that Moses began at this time to write down, under God's inspiration, all the things that he believed were authoritative documents for his people.

## Exodus 24:8

This is the blood of the covenant: Jesus repeated this phrase almost word for word at the Last Supper (Matthew 26:28). See also Hebrews 9:20.

## Exodus 24:10

they saw the God: We must understand this statement in connection with 33:20. In that verse, the Lord says that no one can see him fully and live.

So they did not see God in his full being. They saw some visible form that represented him. The text only describes what was under his feet.

When Isaiah saw the Lord, the only detail given was the edge of his robe (Isaiah 6:1).

## Exodus 24:11

In places around the world, eating a meal together often indicates peace and good relationships. This is true both in the past and today.

## Exodus 24:12

The law and commandments that God inscribed on the tablets of stone were the ten basic principles from 20:3–17 (see 34:28). The specific rules in 21:1–23:33 depended on these principles.

## Exodus 24:17

consuming fire: See 3:2 and the study note.

## Exodus 25:1–27.19

These instructions first list the materials that the Israelites could give to build the tabernacle (25:3–7).

Next, the instructions describe the tabernacle from the center and move outward. They begin with the ark of the covenant (also called the ark of the Testimony, 25:10–22; 27:9–19).

Two items are described later. These are the altar of incense inside the sanctuary and the bronze basin in the courtyard (30:1–10, 17–21).

These items appear in the section about the priesthood. They may be placed there because the priests used them in a special way as part of their service.

## Exodus 25:1–40.38

Unlike most churches today, the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle) was not mainly a place where people gathered to meet. It was first of all the dwelling place of God. It functioned like the palace of a king. God was Israel's divine King, and the Tabernacle was his royal tent.

In this way, churches today are more similar to later Jewish synagogues, where people gathered to worship and learn (see also study note on 40:2).

The last section of Exodus completes God's self-revelation to Israel. Through these events, God brought the people out of the spiritual darkness that had held them in slavery.

This section includes three main parts:

1. Instructions for building the Tent of Meeting (chapters 25–31).
2. The story of the golden calf (a wrong attempt to secure God's presence, chapters 32–34).
3. The report of building the Tent of Meeting (the correct way to secure God's presence, chapters 35–40).

These chapters show that God's ultimate goal in delivering Israel from slavery was to live among them.

God wanted to share his presence with his people. However, because God is holy (completely pure and set apart from sin), people could experience his presence only in the way he commanded.

They could not approach him through pagan practices (worship methods of other nations) or through human manipulation (trying to control or force a god to act).

The building of the Tent of Meeting is described here, even though some instructions in Leviticus were given earlier (see 40:1–2; Leviticus 25:1; 27:34; Numbers 7:1). This event shows the goal of the entire exodus story: God came to live among his people.

## Exodus 25:2

every man whose heart compels him: There is a plain difference between meeting needs in God's way and trying to meet them on our own. For example, Aaron forced people to contribute to making the gold calf (see 32:1–4).

## Exodus 25:8

- a sanctuary: For the people to have a life-giving relationship with God, they needed to understand how completely different God was from them (see study note on 3:5).
- The purpose of this activity was so God could live among them.

## Exodus 25:9

according to the pattern: We cannot choose how to approach a holy God. We must meet God on his terms and in accord with his desires and character.

## Exodus 25:10–22

an ark of acacia wood: Ark is an old English word meaning "box." The ark was Israel's "covenant box." It was the most important item in the entire Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle) because God made his presence available there (25:22). The stone tablets of the covenant were inside the box (25:16, 21). This emphasized that God reveals himself through a mutual commitment between himself and his people.

## Exodus 25:12–15

The carrying poles guaranteed that no one touched this symbol of God's powerful holiness. Later, Uzzah died when he instinctively reached out to steady the ark while they were moving it (see 2 Samuel 6:6–7).

## Exodus 25:17

The Hebrew word translated as mercy seat means "a covering." The cover of the covenant box was where God "covered over" sin (see Leviticus 16:14–16).

## Exodus 25:18

The description of the cherubim only mentions that they had wings (25:20; see 2 Chronicles 3:10–13).

## Exodus 25:22

I will meet with you there: The ark was in the innermost part of the Holy Place (26:33). This inner room was like God's throne room (see study note on Leviticus 16:2).

In many pagan (non-Israelite) temples, an idol stood in that place. An idol is a physical image that people worship as a god. But the tabernacle had no idol. It had only the ark, a sacred box that showed God's covenant faithfulness and grace (his loyal love and undeserved kindness).

God met his people in that setting. He did not meet them through an idol.

An idol shows a false belief about God. It suggests that a god is part of the created world and can be controlled by the right ritual (religious action). It assumes that people can gain blessings without caring about their own character or commitment.

But the Lord is completely separate from this world. He cannot be controlled or forced to act. He wants to bless his people. Yet his blessings are gifts of grace. People must receive them in trust and surrender to him.

## Exodus 25:23–30

The table of acacia wood was on the north side of the main room of the tabernacle (26:35). It reminded the

people that God would provide for them. Most importantly, God's presence is what sustained them (25:30).

## Exodus 25:29

The drink offerings included olive oil and wine (see 29:40).

## Exodus 25:31–39

The lampstand of pure, hammered gold stood on the south side of the tabernacle (26:35). It symbolized God's presence with his people.

The lamps were flat dishes holding olive oil (25:37). A wick extended into the oil and hung from a lip on one side of the dish. The dishes sat on upturned almond blossoms (25:33). The priests positioned them so that all their wicks faced the room's center (25:37).

The total number of lamps is unclear. Exodus 25:37 mentions seven lamps, but there seem to be 22 lamp cups in 25:33–34.

## Exodus 26:1–37

The tabernacle itself (not including the courtyard around it) was not very large. It was about 4.6 meters (15 feet) wide and 13.7 meters (45 feet) long.

The main structure stood on 48 vertical frames. Each frame was 4.6 meters (15 feet) high and 68.6 centimeters (27 inches) wide (26:16). The frames were made of acacia wood and covered with gold (26:15, 29).

Workers joined the frames together with horizontal crossbars. These bars formed a three-sided rectangle with one open end (26:26–28).

Two large linen curtains covered the structure. Each large curtain was made from five smaller curtains joined together. The two large curtains were then connected into one long covering (26:1–6).

This linen covering stretched across the top of the frame. It hung down along the sides and the back. It covered both the walls and the roof.

Over the linen curtain, workers placed another curtain made of goat hair. It was built in the same way. This curtain was 0.9 meters (3 feet) wider and 1.8 meters (6 feet) longer than the linen curtain (26:7–13). Because it was larger, it hung lower on every side.

Above these two curtains were two protective layers. One layer was made from tanned ram skins. The other was made from fine leather (26:14). These outer coverings protected the tabernacle from weather and damage.

Inside the tabernacle, another curtain divided the space into two parts. This curtain was beautifully embroidered. It hung across the width of the structure on four posts made of acacia wood (26:31–33). This created two rooms. The first room was called the Holy Place. The second room was called the Most Holy Place.

## Exodus 26:2–6

The cloth was 13 meters long (42 feet) and two meters wide (six feet). The width of two meters (six feet) may have been because of the largest loom available. They joined five of these six-foot strips, probably by sewing, to create one continuous piece of cloth 13 meters long (42 feet) and 10 meters wide (30 feet). When connected with loops and clasps, the two cloths formed a single unit measuring 13 meters (42 feet) by 20 meters (60 feet) (26:5–6).

## Exodus 26:9

The two goat-hair curtains measured about 14 meters (45 feet) by 20 meters (66 feet) (26:7). The extra two meters (six feet) hung evenly over the front and back of the structure.

## Exodus 26:15

acacia wood: This is a hard wood found in the region of Sinai.

## Exodus 26:19

Each base was under the place where the frames joined. The right peg of one frame and the left peg of the next frame fit into one base. Along with the crossbars, this setup helped stabilize the entire structure (26:27–28).

## Exodus 26:31

Blue, purple, and scarlet are rich colors suitable for the palace of God the king. God may have chosen these dyes because they were easy to find in the desert.

## Exodus 26:33

The Most Holy Place was the earthly dwelling of God. It held the ark of the covenant, where the Lord gave commands to the people of Israel (25:22). The Most Holy Place was about 4.5 meters (15 feet) wide, 4.5 meters (15 feet) deep, and 4.5 meters (15 feet) high.

## Exodus 26:36–37

The curtain at the eastern end was like the one between the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. The posts had bronze bases, not silver ones.

## Exodus 27:1–8

The square altar for burnt offerings, like the tabernacle frames, was made of acacia wood covered with metal. Yet, to match the other features outside the sanctuary, they covered it with bronze (27:2–3; see 27:10, 17, 19).

## Exodus 27:1–19

The plans for the altar of burnt offering and the courtyard extend outward from the center. Like the sanctuary, the plans for the courtyard's furniture are provided before the courtyard itself (27:1–8; 27:9–19).

## Exodus 27:2

Archaeology shows that the horns of the altar were raised parts at the four corners of the altar. They projected upward from each corner.

These horns may have helped keep the wood and offerings from falling off the altar (see Psalm 118:27). They also had meaning related to beliefs about God. The horns represented God's gracious care for his people.

If a person held onto the horns of the altar, that person was asking for mercy in judgment (see 1 Kings 1:50–51; 2:28). This action showed a request for protection or leniency.

The priests put blood on the horns during atonement and purification ceremonies (special rituals to deal with sin and uncleanness; see Exodus 29:12; Leviticus 4:7).

## Exodus 27:5

The altar was evidently a hollow square (27:1, 8), with the grating placed inside it to allow ashes to fall to the ground underneath.

## Exodus 27:9–19

The courtyard plans included curtain walls made of finely woven linen, hanging on posts with bronze bases. The posts were 2.29 meters apart (7.5 feet) and 2.29 meters high (7.5 feet). The curtains formed a rectangle measuring 46 meters long (150 feet) and 22.86 meters wide (75 feet), with a 10-meter opening (30 feet) centered on the east side.

## Exodus 27:16

The curtain covering the gate of the courtyard was similar in color and design to the entrance and dividing curtains of the tabernacle (Exodus 26:31, 36).

## Exodus 27:19

The use of tent pegs indicates that the courtyard posts were not freestanding. Support wires stabilized them.

## Exodus 27:20–21

The first thing said about the function of the priests, Aaron and his sons, is that they were to keep the lamps burning continually through the night (see 30:8). As the lamps burned before the Lord, they showed that God was still present with his people. The light reminded them that his presence continued among them.

## Exodus 27:20–30.38

After explaining how to build the Tent of Meeting, Moses gave instructions for those serving in it and the items used. Included are:

- the priests' duties (27:20–21; 29:38–46),
- the priests' clothing (chapter 28),
- the ceremonies to set the priests apart for service (29:1–37),
- the tabernacle furnishings (30:1–10, 17–21), and
- the supplies used for worship (30:11–16, 22–38).

## Exodus 27:21

the Tent of Meeting: The expression Tent of Meeting sometimes refers to the tabernacle tent. In these cases, Tent of Meeting and tabernacle mean the same thing.

In addition, 33:7–11 also mentions a temporary tent called the Tent of Meeting. This tent was set up outside the camp before the tabernacle was built. See study note on 40:2.

## Exodus 28:1–2

The garments described in this chapter are primarily those for Aaron, the first high priest. The clothing for Aaron's sons, who functioned as his assistants, is described in 28:40–43.

## Exodus 28:1–43

These holy garments for Aaron were to distinguish him as a priest set apart (Hebrew qadash, "consecrated") for the Lord's service (28:2, 3). The beauty of these garments matched the beauty of the Tent of Meeting, which was God's portable earthly palace (or tabernacle).

One day, Jesus Christ, the true High Priest, would enter the Most Holy Place once for all. Then the difference between priests and people would disap-

pear (Hebrews 10:11–22). Until then, human mediators represented how Christ would fulfill the types of wonderful things God accomplishes for his people.

## Exodus 28:6–14

the ephod: The ephod was a kind of apron consisting of front and back pieces joined by shoulder straps and secured with a decorative sash (28:7, 8, 27–28). Moses probably mentions it first because it was a unique garment of the high priest.

Gideon later made a gold ephod. This suggests that people believed the garment had special powers (Judges 8:27).

## Exodus 28:12

names on his two shoulders (see Isaiah 9:6): The badge of office on the shoulder indicated what the person was really carrying. Thus, the high priest represented the people before God, and with his royal garments he represented the glory of God before the people.

## Exodus 28:15–30

The breastpiece receives more attention than any other item. This suggests the breastpiece was very important.

The breastpiece symbolized the priest's representation of Israel (28:17–21, 29). It held the Urim and Thummim, objects through which God revealed his will (28:30).

The high priest had two main tasks. First, he brought the people to God. He represented them before the Lord.

Second, he brought God's word to the people. He spoke to them on God's behalf.

The chestpiece stood for both of these duties. It showed that the high priest served as a bridge between God and the people.

## Exodus 28:29

The high priest would go into the Holy Place (the outer room of the sanctuary) to trim the lamp, replace the bread on the table, and replenish the incense on the altar that stood outside the Most Holy Place.

## Exodus 28:30

the Urim and Thummim: These are Hebrew terms that might translate as lights [or curses] and perfections. These objects were likely two stones. The priest used them to receive a yes-or-no answer from God.

The Bible does not describe what these stones looked like. Other passages further explain their use (see Numbers 27:21; Deuteronomy 33:8; 1 Samuel 28:6; Ezra 2:63; and Nehemiah 7:65).

## Exodus 28:31–35

the robe of the ephod: The bells signaled that the priest was still moving and had not been struck dead by God's presence (see Leviticus 10:1–2). Jewish tradition says that the priest had a cord tied to his ankle. If he died in the Holy Place, others could drag his body out (Exodus 28:35).

## Exodus 28:36–38

Like all other parts of the high priest's clothing and actions, the little gold plate on the front of his turban reminded the people that God is holy. His holiness affected how they could enter his presence. God wanted to live with his people, but his holiness would harm them unless he took protective measures. God decides how we can enter his presence, not us.

The Bible's main question is how sinful people can live with a holy God so that God can share his holy character with them. Jesus Christ, the Holy One of God, provides the answer. He is the perfect mediator (Luke 4:34; Hebrews 9:11–15). He did not die only to save us from the consequences of our sins. He died so that God can live in us and create his holy character in us (Ephesians 2:10; 4:22; Philippians 1:27; 1 Peter 1:13–16).

## Exodus 28:39

The tunic was probably a shirt worn under the robe (see 29:5).

## Exodus 28:42–43

In many pagan religions, sexual acts were part of worship. People believed they could control fertility (the ability to have children, crops, and animals) through sexual activity.

In some places, priests even served their gods without clothing. These practices were attempts to influence the powers of nature.

In the worship of the Lord, no form of sexual manipulation was allowed. God's blessings cannot be gained through magical actions or human control.

For this reason, even the accidental exposure of the genitals was carefully avoided. Worship of the Lord had to reflect his holiness and purity.

## Exodus 29:1

without blemish: This phrase uses the same Hebrew word that is translated blameless and perfect when referring to human and divine behavior (for example, Genesis 17:1; Psalm 18:30, 32).

The animal offered as a sacrifice had to be without physical flaws. This showed that the sacrifice represented God's own character. It also showed the kind of character God desires in human beings.

## Exodus 29:1–37

Moses had to consecrate (or sanctify) Aaron and his sons to serve the Lord. The focus on making the priests holy appears throughout the ceremonies (29:6, 21, 28, 29, 34, 36, 37). God set them apart not only for service. But he set them apart to serve a God whose nature is very different from that of sinful humans. Leviticus 8 gives the account of how they followed these instructions.

## Exodus 29:4

wash them with water: This action showed an important truth. No one can live in God's presence while carrying the filth of sin in their lives (29:21).

The washing did not remove sin by itself. It was a sign. It showed that people must be made clean before coming near to God.

## Exodus 29:7

The anointing oil empowered a person for a task through the Holy Spirit (see Isaiah 61:1).

## Exodus 29:9

- permanent: The fulfillment of this promise, like the one to King David, clearly extends beyond human limits. Aaron behaved badly (for example, chapter 32; Numbers 11). His sons and descendants were no better (1 Samuel 2:12–17; Isaiah 28:7; Ezekiel 8:15–16; Malachi 2:1–9). The promise could only find its ultimate fulfillment in Jesus Christ (see Hebrews 7:26; 9:11).
- to ordain (literally you will fill the hands of): This means to give a person a task to perform.

## Exodus 29:10–34

The consecration of Aaron's priesthood involved:

- a sin offering (29:10–14),
- a burnt offering (29:15–18), and
- an ordination offering (29:19–28).

These patterns were later used for the people's regular offerings (see 29:38–46; Leviticus 1–5). In each case, Aaron and his sons placed their hands on the heads of the sacrificial animals (Exodus 29:10, 15, 19). This act showed that sin is a matter of life and death. God will only remove sin by a death.

Because it represents life, blood was important in these ceremonies (29:12, 16, 20, 21).

## Exodus 29:13

The fat was considered the best part and so was given to God.

## Exodus 29:14

- The remains stood for what was unclean in human behavior. They symbolized actions and attitudes that were sinful or morally impure.
- sin offering: See Leviticus 4.

## Exodus 29:15–18

The next offering was a gift of thanks to God. It also represented fully dedicating oneself to God.

## Exodus 29:18

pleasing aroma: Such language is anthropomorphism, describing God with human terms and experiences. God's delight in an appropriately offered sacrifice is like a human's enjoyment of a pleasing smell.

## Exodus 29:19–28

This ordination offering is very similar to the peace offering, which is also called the fellowship offering (Leviticus 3).

In this offering, the fat was burned as a gift to the Lord. The breast and the thigh were first lifted up before the Lord as a sign that they belonged to him (29:24–26). After that, they became the portion for the priests to eat (29:26–28).

In a regular peace offering, the person who brought the sacrifice also ate part of the meat. This meal was a fellowship meal shared in God's presence (Leviticus 7:11–18). In this case, the priests ate the meal as part of their ordination (Exodus 29:31–34).

## Exodus 29:20–21

The placing of the blood on the earlobes, thumbs, and big toes represented dedication of the entire person to God. Sprinkling it on their clothes indicated that the clothing, too, could be used only for holy purposes.

## Exodus 29:30

The son who succeeds him: Each high priest who came after him had to be ordained in the same way. Ordained means formally set apart and appointed for holy service.

## Exodus 29:31

This holy place was probably in the courtyard of the tabernacle.

## Exodus 29:32–34

Eating in the presence of the Lord showed a close relationship with him (as in 24:9–11).

## Exodus 29:33

atonement: Traditionally, atonement has often been explained as a "covering over." This means that sin is covered so it no longer stands between God and people.

Some modern scholars connect the word to another Semitic root (a related word family from ancient Middle Eastern languages). That root does not appear elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible. Based on that idea, they understand the word to mean "blot out," "erase," or "cleanse."

In both views, the result is the same. The effects of sin are removed. Because of this, people and even sacred objects can remain in God's presence without being destroyed.

## Exodus 29:37

As with the priests, the altar was to be made holy so it could be used in service of the holy God.

## Exodus 29:38–41

Offering the daily sacrifices was one of the chief functions of the priest.

## Exodus 29:42–46

The purpose of the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle), the priesthood, and the sacrificial system was to help people have fellowship with God. Fellowship means a close relationship. The Lord would meet with his people there (29:42, 43). He would live among them as their God (29:45, 46).

## Exodus 29:46

The purpose of the Exodus was to reveal the grace, power, and holiness of God and to enable humans to experience God's presence in their lives.

## Exodus 30:1–10

The plans for the altar made of acacia wood are described here instead of with the other items of the holy place (25:23–40). This might be because of the reference to the priest's use of it in 30:7–10.

## Exodus 30:6

- in front of the veil: This refers to the Holy Place, just outside the Most Holy Place where the ark was.
- The rising smoke of the incense symbolized prayer. Believers now have constant access to God in prayer through the continuous atonement provided by Christ (see Psalm 141:2; Luke 1:10; Revelation 5:8; 8:3–4).

## Exodus 30:12

no plague: Compare 2 Samuel 24, where a plague followed King David's unauthorized census. A king would often take a census for reasons of pride or control. Here the people are giving God a ransom for themselves. This standard payment would go into the tabernacle treasury and initially be used in the construction of the tabernacle (see Exodus 38:25–26).

## Exodus 30:17–21

On why the plans for the bronze washbasin are included here, see study note on 30:1–10.

## Exodus 30:22–38

Because God is absolutely unique (holy), what is used for his service cannot be used for any other purpose. This was the point made to Moses at the burning bush (see study note on 3:5). It was so important for the people to understand this that disobedience in this matter involved a severe punishment (30:33).

## Exodus 30:33

cut off from his people: Either by death or by expulsion. In some cases, God brought death as a direct judgment. In other cases, the person was removed from the community.

## Exodus 31:1–11

God gave instructions for the tabernacle complex and for those who would serve in it. He also chose and empowered those who would do the work.

## Exodus 31:3

I have filled him with the Spirit of God: This is one of the earliest references to being filled with the Spirit as an expression of divine empowerment for activities

that are clearly beyond normal human abilities (see also Genesis 41:38; Numbers 11:17; Judges 6:34; 14:19; 1 Samuel 10:6; 16:13; Joel 2:28–29; Micah 3:8).

## Exodus 31:6

God gave detailed and remarkable instructions. He also provided skilled craftsmen who could complete the work exactly as he commanded.

In this way, God supplied what his people needed to obey him. This idea is similar to a prayer by Augustine in his book Confessions: "Give what you command, and command what you will" (10.29). Augustine meant that God must give people the ability to do what he requires.

## Exodus 31:11

The main idea of this whole section (25:1–40:38) is clear. God wanted to meet his people's need for a visible sign of his presence. They needed something they could see that reminded them that he was with them.

However, this had to be done exactly as God commanded. God set the way his people were to approach him. He determines the terms by which people come to him, not human beings.

## Exodus 31:12–18

The Sabbath was understood to be the unique sign of the covenant (31:13, 16, 17; see also 20:8–11; Isaiah 58:13–14; Jeremiah 17:21–27; Nehemiah 13:15–22). The Sabbath also played an important role in God's plan to make his people holy. Holy refers to being set apart for God's special use and sharing his character (Exodus 31:13, 14, 15).

By resting on the Sabbath, the people showed that they belonged to him. They stopped their own work on that day (31:15, 17).

This rest was also a practical way to show trust in God. It showed that they depended on him to provide what they needed (see 20:8–11 and study notes).

## Exodus 31:14–15

It is very important to learn that we find life in God only by coming to him in his way.

This truth is made clear by the death penalty for disobedience (see also Numbers 15:32–36). This does not mean that God's people must punish these sins in the same way. But at the beginning, God needed to make this truth clear (see Acts 5:1–11).

If people do not understand this spiritual lesson, ritual obedience will not help them. Ritual obedience means simply following religious rules. It has no value without true faith and trust in God (see Colossians 2:16–19).

## Exodus 31:18

- Normally, each party to a covenant received a written copy of the terms of the covenant. So it may be that the two stone tablets were identical, one being God's copy and the other the people's copy, to be kept together in the ark of the covenant.
- finger of God: See 34:28.

## Exodus 32:1

The Israelites acted out of fear, disrespect for Moses, disbelief in God's leadership, and denial of responsibility. They did not want to wait for God to show his care for them. Not waiting for God often leads to sin (see 1 Samuel 13:7–13; Isaiah 30:15–18).

## Exodus 32:1–6

The people were not willing to wait and see what God had been saying to Moses on the mountain for the 40 days while he was there (see 24:18).

## Exodus 32:1–35

Moses had been gone for many days. While waiting at the bottom of Mount Sinai, the people wanted protection, guidance, and a way to show their worship. God understood this and wanted to help them (see chapters 25–31). But the Israelites tried to meet their needs on their own. Fellowship with God requires relying on him (see John 15:5; 2 Corinthians 3:5).

## Exodus 32:2–4

Aaron, who served as a priest (religious leader), asked the people to bring gold rings. After that, he did not allow them to take part in the work.

This was very different from what God commanded for building the tabernacle. In that case, the people were invited to bring many kinds of offerings as they were willing (25:1–9; 35:4–36:7).

They also shared in the work under the direction of a skilled worker whom God filled with his Spirit, not under a priest acting alone (31:1–6; 36:1–2).

## Exodus 32:4

- fashioned it into a molten calf: The idol might have been a bull, similar to the Egyptian god Amon-Re, which the people knew from Egypt. The bull represented power, domination, and fertility. The writer

might have said calf to despise the idol. Or, Aaron might have made a calf, thinking this sin was less severe than making a full-sized bull.
- These, O Israel, are your gods, who brought you up out: The people credited the idol with what they had just said Moses did (32:1). Idolatry shows the belief that the divine and visible worlds are continuous. This view suggests one can access divine power by manipulating the god through the idol.

God insisted the opposite is true. God's creation cannot contain or limit him. No one can receive his blessing by manipulating creation, either in a ceremony or otherwise. God's blessings are for those who give up their own efforts to feel secure and come to him in the ways he has revealed.

## Exodus 32:5

- Aaron tried to manage the process, but he gave up leadership by simply doing what he thought people wanted.
- Although Aaron called the idol "your gods" (32:4), he also suggested it was a physical manifestation of the Lord.

## Exodus 32:6

The Hebrew term translated as indulge in revelry is traditionally translated as they got up to play. In Hebrew, like in English, the word play can imply sexual activities (see Genesis 26:8, "caressing"). This is likely the case here.

Worship of a fertility symbol, such as a bull, often included the worshipers engaging in sexual activities (see 1 Corinthians 10:7–8).

## Exodus 32:7

your people, whom you brought up out of the land of Egypt: Here God attributes his own work to Moses. This suggests God was testing Moses, giving him a chance to avoid the same mistake the people made (32:1). God was not tempting Moses to do wrong (see James 1:13–14). But he placed Moses in a situation with a clear choice that could lead in different directions (compare 1 Kings 22:19–23).

## Exodus 32:9–10

God was apparently ready to reject his people. They had broken their covenant (their binding agreement) with him.

## Exodus 32:10

- Now leave me alone: This sounded like a command, but it was actually an invitation. God was giving Moses an opportunity to pray for the people. Moses was to stand before God as an intercessor (a person who speaks to God on behalf of others).

The people deserved to be destroyed because of their sin. However, God was willing to spare them if Moses continued to pray for them.
- I will make you into a great nation: God told Moses that he could begin again with him alone. God could abandon the other descendants of Abraham and build a new nation from the children of Moses.

This was likely a test. It showed whether Moses understood God's character and his promises.

## Exodus 32:11–13

If there was a test, Moses passed it. He refused to take God's place (32:11). He knew God is just and faithful and would not save people just to destroy them (32:12). He declined the offer to become the father of a great nation because it would mean God violating promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (32:13). Moses understood who God truly is.

## Exodus 32:14

In response to the argument of Moses, the Lord changed his mind.

This does not show God as an angry ruler who must be forced to calm down. The Bible does not present him as a tyrant who is difficult to persuade.

Instead, the Lord is more willing to show mercy than to bring punishment. He invites those who are close to him, like Moses, to pray and speak on behalf of others.

Through faithful intercession (prayer on behalf of someone else), God gives an opportunity for mercy.

## Exodus 32:15–29

When Moses saw what was happening, he became much less calm than he was on the mountain. He smashed the two tablets (32:15–19). He destroyed the calf (32:20). He confronted Aaron (32:21–25). He ordered the death of the rebellious leaders (32:26–29).

## Exodus 32:16

The tablets were the work of God: The covenant was more than just a human agreement.

## Exodus 32:19

Moses might have shattered the tablets out of anger. It could also have been his way of saying the people shattered the covenant with God. Later, God reminded Moses that he was the one who broke the tablets (see 34:1).

## Exodus 32:20

Passing the gold powder of the image through the bodies of the people effectively rendered it unclean.

## Exodus 32:21–25

Aaron denied responsibility, even though he made the molds and poured the gold (32:4). Aaron wanted Moses to believe it all just happened (32:24). He implied he had no choice because the people were so evil (32:22).

Aaron did not fool Moses. Moses knew Aaron could have led the people, but instead, he allowed them to get completely out of control (32:25).

## Exodus 32:25

a laughingstock to their enemies: After the Israelites' great show of worshiping the Lord as a different kind of God, their actions proclaimed that he was merely another of the idols that their enemies had been worshiping all along (see Ezekiel 36:19–20).

## Exodus 32:26–29

Moses had asked God to spare the people, but now he called on those who followed the Lord to kill those who had sinned. The Levites (32:26) were willing to confront the sin that Aaron had let loose. Although Moses commanded them to kill everyone (32:27), the number 3,000 (32:28) makes it clear that the words each of you had a restricted meaning.

The reference to his son and his brother suggests that as Aaron had led in the idolatry, many of the Levites had led in the worship of the idol, and they were the ones that the rest of the Levites killed. Aaron may have escaped because God had already designated him as high priest (28:1).

## Exodus 32:30–35

This further intercession for the people may have been needed because of the new recognition Moses had of how serious the sin really was.

## Exodus 32:32

Earlier, God had offered to make Moses into a great nation instead of the people. Moses had refused that offer.

Here, Moses again showed his loyalty to the people. He asked God to destroy him also if God chose not to forgive them.

## Exodus 32:33

God did not grant what Moses requested. Instead, God said he would judge only those who had sinned in that event.

## Exodus 32:34

- the place I described: This refers to Canaan, which God promised to give to Abraham's descendants (see 3:17; 32:13; 33:1).
- on the day I settle accounts: Because of God's mercy, judgment may not always come immediately. But in this instance, God soon sent a plague (32:35). Judgment will come for those who continue to sin (see Matthew 13:24–30).

## Exodus 33:1–6

God would not lead the people up to Canaan as he had previously led them (see 33:3; but also 33:14–17). Instead, he would send an angel (33:2).

## Exodus 33:2–3

- an angel ... But I will not go with you: This angel might not be the "angel of the LORD," since in Exodus and other parts of the Old Testament, the angel of the LORD is closely associated with God's presence (see 3:2; 23:20–23).

Or, God might have meant that while he would lead them through the angel (33:2), he would not live among them in the tabernacle as planned (33:3).

- Canaanites ... Jebusites: See study note on 3:8.

## Exodus 33:3

- land flowing with milk and honey: Canaan was not as fertile as the Nile Valley in Egypt, but it was much more productive than the Sinai desert.
- stiff-necked people: They did not keep their promises.
- I might destroy you: As God of the covenant, the Lord would enforce the covenant terms that required the destruction of those who violated it (see study note on 23:20–33; also see 24:7–8 and study notes).

## Exodus 33:4–6

People might have worn jewelry and fine clothes while worshiping the gold calf. Removing them here shows mourning and repentance (33:4).

### Exodus 33:7

The tabernacle is often called the Tent of Meeting (see study note on 27:21). In many passages, these two expressions refer to the same structure.

However, in this passage, the Tent of Meeting refers to a different, temporary tent. Moses set up this tent outside the camp before the tabernacle was built.

Later, when the tabernacle was completed, it was placed in the center of the camp (see Numbers 2:1–31).

### Exodus 33:7–11

The way God communicated with his people before the completion of the tabernacle is likely described here. This helps explain the events recorded in 33:1–6 and 33:12–23.

### Exodus 33:8–11

would stand ... stand up and bow down: The people considered it amazing that Moses spoke directly to God, "face to face" (33:11).

### Exodus 33:11

Joshua had earlier gained experience as a military leader (see 17:9–13). Now, he was gaining experience as a spiritual leader (see also 24:13). He may have stayed behind to guard the tent, a function the Levites would later fulfill with the tabernacle (1 Chronicles 26).

### Exodus 33:12

I know you by name: God chose Moses himself.

### Exodus 33:12–23

Moses begged God to go with him and the people to the promised land. In these verses, the word Presence usually translates a Hebrew word that literally means "face" (33:14–15).

Earlier in the chapter, we learn that the Lord spoke with Moses "face to face" (33:11). This phrase describes a close and direct relationship. It does not mean that Moses saw God's physical face. It means that God spoke with Moses in a clear and personal way.

Moses wanted that same close relationship to continue. He did not want God to send only an angel or messenger. He wanted God's own presence to go with them. Moses also wanted the people to share in that relationship in some way.

### Exodus 33:13

- please let me know Your ways: Moses did not just want God's blessings. He wanted to understand God's nature and character. He also wanted to know why and how God acted. God's goal of revealing himself was starting to happen, at least with Moses.
- Moses wanted God to accompany them because they were the Lord's own people.

### Exodus 33:14

I will give you rest: Literally a place to roost, as in a place where a bird can land and be at peace. Ever since Abraham left Ur, he and his descendants had had no such place.

### Exodus 33:15–16

Moses made his request more direct. He showed he understood God's actions. The exodus was not just about leaving Egypt for Canaan. It was about experiencing God personally, which would change their lives. Without this, staying at Mount Sinai would have been better. Going to Canaan without the Lord would be disastrous.

### Exodus 33:17

The Lord reaffirmed his agreement to go with them and his personal appointment of Moses.

### Exodus 33:18

Moses asked for confirmation of God's promises. He asked to see God's glorious presence (literally glory). He was asking for an experience of seeing the very essence of God (see study note on 16:7).

### Exodus 33:19

- In his positive reply, God changed the terms of the request Moses made. God promised Moses a glorious experience, but he would not let Moses see his face. In the Old Testament, seeing God's face means seeing God fully and directly.

Instead, God said he would show Moses his goodness. He would also proclaim his name. In the Bible, a name often expresses a person's character and identity. God's character is shown especially in his mercy and compassion (see Romans 9:14–16).

- the LORD: In many English Bibles, the word LORD (written in capital letters) stands for the personal name of God, Yahweh.

In this verse, God emphasizes his personal name. This name shows that he is not distant. He is the covenant God (the God who makes promises) of his people.

## Exodus 33:20–23

God desires to reveal his character to his people. However, to see his face means to see his full being (his true and complete nature). No human can see God in this way and live.

God's glorious presence is described in 33:22. That kind of direct encounter would bring death to a human person. God allowed Moses to see only a small part of his glory. Moses was given a brief glimpse, but nothing more.

## Exodus 34:1–3

God called Moses to come back up Mount Sinai with two new stone tablets. The restrictions for the rest of the people are like those made at first (see 19:12–13, 21–25).

## Exodus 34:1–35

God granted the request of Moses (33:18). He showed Moses his goodness (34:1–9). He renewed the covenant (34:10–35).

This renewal was a statement made by God alone. God promised to stay with his people, keeping his covenant promises even though they had broken the covenant and deserved death and abandonment (32:1–6).

## Exodus 34:5–6

the LORD: This represents the personal name of God, Yahweh. This name appears five times in this passage. By repeating this name, God emphasizes his personal name. This shows that he is speaking and acting as the covenant God (the God who makes promises) of his people.

## Exodus 34:5–9

Moses experienced God's presence in a revelation of the name, or character, of God. As God had promised (33:19), he showed Moses the glory of his goodness.

## Exodus 34:6

compassionate and gracious (see 20:5–6; 33:19 and study notes): The Creator who was revealing himself to the Israelites, and through them to the world, is a God of grace. Neither his justice nor his sovereignty are underlined here, as true as those attributes are. If God were merely just, the Old Testament would have ended at this point, or it would have picked up and started again with an entirely new family.

This did not happen because God, in his unique character, is slow to anger and full of unfailing love and faithfulness. These qualities were the basis for his renewal of the covenant.

## Exodus 34:7

- God's unfailing love and his generous desire to forgive are not weakness or indecisiveness, nor are they reason to sin. Sin will have its effects, because God created a world of cause and effect. The murderer may repent, be forgiven, and lead a new life, but the effects of previous choices will continue to play out. We should not sin just because we know that God will forgive (see study note on 20:5–6).
- a thousand generations: See Deuteronomy 7:9–11.
- He will visit the iniquity of the fathers: Our sins affect future generations, but God limits the effects to three or four generations. See also Exodus 20:5–6.

## Exodus 34:8–9

Since the Lord had already twice promised to go with them (33:14, 17)this renewed request seems to show a lack of faith. It may also be that God's presence had driven home to Moses how absolutely holy God is and how very different he is from this stubborn and rebellious people.

Here, Moses took his request a step further and asked God to travel with the people and make them his own treasured possession (see 19:5–6). Moses asked for the complete restoration of the relationship.

## Exodus 34:10–11

God promised to miraculously care for his people as he brought them into Canaan. This care depended on their obedience. In Hebrew, the word translated as observe also means "obey" (34:11). Unlike English, Hebrew does not separate hearing a command from obeying it.

## Exodus 34:10–26

Some of the terms of the covenant are restated, particularly those that prohibit the worship of other gods and that describe the proper worship of the Lord.

## Exodus 34:12–17

Worship of idols was prohibited, particularly the idols of the peoples into whose lands the Israelites were going. A key part of this restriction was the ban on treaties, or covenants, with these idol-worshiping peoples. Making a treaty would mean acknowledging their gods, as ancient treaties often called upon gods as witnesses (see study note on 20:1–23:33).

The treaties would also tempt the Israelites to adopt the customs of their treaty partners (34:12, 15–16).

### Exodus 34:13

- Asherah was a Canaanite fertility goddess who would continue to be a temptation throughout Israel's history (see, for example, Judges 6:25; 1 Kings 14:15; 2 Kings 23:15).
- The Aherah poles seem to have been fertility symbols.

### Exodus 34:16

Marriage with people who worshiped other gods was a problem throughout the Old Testament. God warned His people not to marry those who followed other gods (see Genesis 24:3; Ezra 9:1–2; compare 2 Corinthians 6:14–18).

### Exodus 34:22

Feast of Ingathering: See study notes on 23:16; Leviticus 23:15–21, 34–43.

### Exodus 34:23

three times: See 23:14–17.

### Exodus 34:24

no one will covet your land: If Israel would trust God and obey him, he would protect them.

### Exodus 34:27–28

Moses wrote down these repeated instructions that explained the main terms of the covenant (34:27).

The Ten Commandments, which summarize these terms, were written on the new stone tablets (34:28).

### Exodus 34:29–35

Moses, who had asked to see the glory of God, was not aware that his own face reflected that glory.

### Exodus 34:33

he put a veil over his face: While Moses was reporting what God had said to him, he left his face unveiled. Then he covered it, perhaps because of the fear its brightness caused during normal conversation (34:30; see 2 Corinthians 3:7–18 for the apostle Paul's thoughts on this event).

### Exodus 35:1–40.38

Much of the report about building the Tent of Meeting repeats what 25:1–31:18 said. There is a change from the imperative mood to the indicative, and there are certain changes in the order.

This repetition emphasizes that the work was done exactly as God commanded (see 40:16). The people had tried to secure God's presence their own way with the gold calf, which led to disaster. Now, by following God's way, they received blessings (40:34–38).

### Exodus 35:4–36.7

At the creation of the gold calf, Aaron asked only for earrings (see study note on 32:2–4). Here, Moses invites the people to bring various gifts (35:4–9). They gave as their hearts and spirits inspired them (35:21). Everyone could contribute something and the giving was voluntary. So, the people ended up giving too much and Moses had to stop them (36:4–7).

### Exodus 37:1–29

It says that Bezalel made the ark of the covenant and all the furnishings, as well as the courtyard and its furnishings (37:1, 10, 17, 25; 38:1, 8, 9, 18). But this probably means he was in charge and guided the other craftsmen and seamstresses.

### Exodus 38:1–20

This section reports on building the courtyard (38:9–20) and its equipment, including the altar of burnt offering and the bronze basin (38:1–7; 38:8).

### Exodus 38:8

- The plans for the bronze basin were part of the instructions to the priests (30:17–21; 29:38–30:38). Here, however, the text reports how the basin was built, following a logical order.
- This bronze, which they could polish to look like mirrors, was probably of very high quality. It was suitable for use in God's Tent of Meeting.

### Exodus 38:21

Since the tabernacle contained the ark of the covenant (also called the ark of the Testimony), it is called the tabernacle of the Testimony.

### Exodus 38:21–29

The very large amount of metal listed here includes more than one metric ton (about 1,000 kilograms) of gold, almost four metric tons (about 4,000 kilograms) of silver, and two and a half metric tons (about 2,500 kilograms) of bronze.

This large supply shows how eager the Egyptians were to send the Israelites away. The Egyptians gave the

Israelites whatever they asked for so that they would leave quickly (see 12:35–36).

## Exodus 38:26

- For the earlier discussion of this tax, see 30:11–16. The sanctuary shekel was the standard used to measure other weights accurately.
- 603,550: See study note on 12:37.

## Exodus 39:1–31

See Exodus 28:1–43.

## Exodus 39:30

The term holy crown might be a formal title. The initial description of the plate in 28:36 does not include that term.

## Exodus 39:32–43

Moses inspected the completed work and confirmed that everything was as the Lord had commanded (39:43). As a result, Moses blessed them instead of judging them. This was unlike when they tried to enter God's presence in their own ways (32:27).

## Exodus 40:1–33

- The report on setting up the Tent of Meeting starts with the Lord's commands (40:1–15). It continues with how Moses obeyed those commands (40:16–33).
- The repeated statement that "Moses did everything just as the LORD had commanded" (40:16, 19, 21, 23, 25, 27, 29, 32) strongly contrasts with Aaron's self-serving statement in 32:22–24. God wants to share his presence with us, but his holiness requires us to give up our own efforts to secure his presence and gifts.

## Exodus 40:2

- In the Tent of Meeting, God met with Israel to communicate his will to them.
- On the first day of the new year, they set up the Tent of Meeting. This was one year after God announced the Passover and the beginning of Israel's calendar.

## Exodus 40:3

Testimony (Hebrew 'eduth): This word refers especially to the covenant laws (stipulations, meaning the required commands).

A written copy of these laws was placed inside the ark. This copy served as a witness to the covenant that Israel had made with God.

## Exodus 40:33

So Moses finished the work: This statement marks the completion of the work on the tabernacle. The long process of building and preparing all its parts had now come to an end. See study note on 37:1–29.

## Exodus 40:34–38

The most important part of the exodus happened when the glory of the Lord filled the Tent of Meeting.

From the beginning, God's purpose was not only to rescue Israel from slavery. He wanted to bring them into a close relationship with himself. Their greatest need was to know God personally.

Without God's presence, the promised land would not truly be a place of blessing. But now it would be different. The same glory that appeared on Mount Sinai was now with Israel. It would not stay behind. It would travel with them wherever they went.

## Exodus 40:38

all the house of Israel: This description reminds us of how the book of Exodus began (see 1:1–7). At that time, Jacob's family had grown into a large group in Egypt. Later, they became slaves there. This was a dramatic change. They were no longer slaves. Now they were free.

God had promised Abraham that his descendants would bring blessing to all the nations (Genesis 12:3).